

Teen shot in Amar Colony dies, 2 more accused arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Khushi Mehrotra

A 17-year-old boy who was shot in the head in Delhi's Amar Colony last week succumbed to his injuries on Monday, prompting police to add murder charges to the case.

Sai Kumar, a Class 12 student of Blue Bells School, died around 11.45 am after remaining on ventilator support since the May 26 shooting. His body has been kept at AIIMS, where a post-mortem examination is expected on Tuesday.

Meanwhile, Delhi Police arrested two more accused in connection with the case. The accused have been identified as Yash Bidhuri, a resident of Tughlakabad, and Jai Kumar. With the latest arrests, three people, including a juvenile, have been apprehended so far.

A senior police officer said the Crime Branch, which is



investigating the case, will add Section 103 (murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita to the FIR following the teenager's death.

Police had earlier apprehended a 16-year-old boy from Okhla on May 28 and recovered an automatic pistol allegedly used in the crime. Investigators noted that the accused reportedly have criminal records.

According to police, the incident took place on the evening of May 26 when Sai had gone to an eatery in

Amar Colony with a female friend. The victim's family alleged that three boys made remarks about the girl, leading to an argument. The accused allegedly left the spot, returned with a firearm, assaulted Sai and shot him in the head.

Police said the altercation may have begun after one of the accused brushed past Sai's chair.

Sai's father, Sunil Kumar, said his son had gone out with friends after completing his Class 12 examinations.

Delhi Cabinet clears amnesty relief for J&K migrant families

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Cabinet has approved a one-time amnesty scheme and relaxed eligibility conditions for displaced families from Jammu and Kashmir living in the national Capital. The move is expected to benefit 1,832 registered migrant families receiving monthly relief assistance from the Government.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced the decision on Monday, saying the Government was committed to the welfare, dignity, and rehabilitation of migrant families displaced from Jammu and Kashmir.

Under the revised policy, the Delhi Government has removed income-related eligibility restrictions for beneficiaries under the Ad-Hoc Monthly Relief (AMR) scheme. Ownership of immovable property will also no longer affect eligibility for relief.

Officials said the decision applies to registered Jammu and Kashmir migrant families

who had received relief assistance up to March 31, 2024. The Chief Minister said the Government had introduced the one-time amnesty scheme to correct and update beneficiary records while ensuring that genuine families continue to receive assistance without disruption.

Under the scheme, beneficiaries will be allowed to update family details and Aadhaar information in Government records. Officials said the exercise is aimed at improving accuracy in the database and streamlining future relief distribution.

The Government also decided not to recover any excess payment that may have been made earlier because of technical errors or incorrect records. "The objective is to ensure that relief reaches only genuine and eligible families in a transparent and uninterrupted manner," the Chief Minister said.

The Cabinet has extended the cut-off date for the amnesty scheme from



October 1, 2025, to April 1, 2026, giving beneficiaries additional time to update their records and complete formalities. The Government has also extended provisions related to pending relief dues. Earlier, arrears could be cleared only up to September 30, 2025. The revised decision now allows payment of pending dues up to March 31, 2026.

Officials said existing provisions related to the addition or deletion of family members and family bifurcation would continue under

prescribed rules. Verification of claims may also be carried out by Sub-Divisional Magistrates and Tehsildars wherever required.

The Chief Minister said financial assistance would continue to be distributed through Aadhaar-based Direct Benefit Transfer to ensure transparency and timely payments. According to the Government, relief assistance under the AMR scheme is available for a maximum of four members in a family.

The Delhi Government has allocated Rs 30 crore for the

implementation of the scheme during the 2026-27 financial year. Officials said relief expenditure under the scheme has been continuing for several years, with payments made regularly between 2019-20 and 2024-25. Following Aadhaar verification and updating of records, the number of beneficiaries has become more accurate in recent years, resulting in lower expenditure under the scheme, officials added.

Chief Minister said the Delhi Government would ensure that no eligible migrant family faces difficulties in receiving relief assistance. She said the Government remained committed to protecting the interests of displaced families from Jammu and Kashmir and would continue taking steps related to their welfare and rehabilitation.

Thousands of Kashmiri migrant families displaced during the militancy period in Jammu and Kashmir continue to reside in Delhi and other parts of the country.

Two fires within hours: Woman hurt in Mukherjee Nagar and minor fire reported at architecture school

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two separate fire incidents were reported in Delhi within hours of each other, with a blaze at a paying guest accommodation building in northwest Delhi's Mukherjee Nagar area late Sunday night leaving one woman student injured, and a minor fire breaking out at the School of Planning and Architecture campus in central Delhi on Monday morning, though no injuries or property damage were reported in the second incident.

In the first incident, the Delhi Fire Service received a call at 10:29 pm on Sunday about a fire at a ground-plus-three-storey building in Indira Vihar, Mukherjee Nagar. Five fire tenders were immediately rushed to the spot. The fire began on the ground floor, where electrical items



Fire service vehicles at the site after a fire broke out on the second floor of the Ministry of Education office located within the School of Planning and Architecture (SPA) campus in New Delhi on Monday

were stored, and spread rapidly, engulfing portions of the building up to the second floor before being brought under control at 12:15 am. Preliminary information suggests a short circuit as the possible cause.

All occupants of the building were evacuated in time. A woman student sustained minor injuries during the incident and was taken to a nearby hospital for treat-

ment. The building owner, Surender Pal, 65, who lives on the first floor, was among those safely evacuated. Furniture and other household items were damaged in the fire.

Police said they rushed to the spot soon after receiving information and found the building engulfed in smoke. Prompt action was taken to evacuate all occupants before firefighters

doused the blaze.

The second fire broke out on Monday morning at the School of Planning and Architecture campus on Vikas Marg in the ITO area of central Delhi. The Delhi Fire Service received a call at 9:37 am, following which eight fire tenders were dispatched to the location. The flames were brought under control within an hour.

The incident initially caused some confusion when the DFS described the fire as having broken out on the second floor of a Ministry of Education office. The Ministry of Education subsequently clarified that its offices are located at Kartavya Bhavan-2 on Dr Rajendra Prasad Road and have no connection to the fire. The blaze, the ministry confirmed, occurred at the SPA campus at Indraprastha Estate, Vikas Marg, which is a separate location.

Capital begins massive rainwater harvesting push before monsoon

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Jal Board has launched a large-scale rainwater harvesting campaign ahead of the monsoon, with plans to build 500 new recharge structures and restore 1,000 non-functional systems across Government buildings in the Capital. The initiative is aimed at strengthening groundwater reserves and improving long-term water security in the city.

Officials said the first phase of the programme will cover buildings belonging to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Public Works Department, Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board, Directorate of Education and several other Government agencies. Work is expected to begin in June and conclude before the end of the month.

The Delhi Jal Board, which is the nodal agency for rainwater harvesting in the city, said tenders are being issued immediately and work orders will be released in the first



Week of June. All projects under Phase I are targeted for completion by June 30.

The move comes at a time when Delhi continues to face falling groundwater levels in several areas and rising pressure on water resources during summer months. Officials said the upcoming monsoon provides a critical opportunity to capture rainwater and channel it back into the ground instead of allowing it to flow into drains.

According to official figures, around 7,596 of Delhi's 9,148 Government buildings already have rainwater harvesting systems. However, many of these structures have stopped functioning due to poor maintenance and lack of regular monitoring.

SVC CO-OPERATIVE BANK LTD.
(Multi-State Scheduled Bank)

LEGAL RECOVERY DEPARTMENT, REGIONAL OFFICE II, FIRST FLOOR, #27, MOUNT JOY ROAD, HANUMANTHANAGAR, BANGALURU - 560019. CON NO. 080 26603994/95

DEMAND NOTICE
Ref No: CO-SVC: BNG-L&R: 11-2026-27: **Date : 21.05.2026**
1. Mr. Rahul Kumar H No.RDZ 1/139, Gali Number 5, Palam Enclave, Palam Village, Southwest Delhi, Delhi - 110045
2. S. V. Gayatri Devi Talatam Flat no b-303 Jampa delight 4th T Cross South Kalena Agrahara M LA Layout Bannerghatta Road Bangalore.
Sub: Notice under Sub-Section (2) of Section 13 of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 as amended by The Enforcement of Security Interest and Recovery of Debts Laws and Miscellaneous Provisions (Amdt.) Act, 2016 (44 of 2016), dt. 18-01-2017 and further amended by Security Interest (Enforcement) (Amendment) Rules, 2018.
Sir/Madam,
We, SVC CO-OPERATIVE BANK LTD. (Formerly The Shamrao Vithal Co-op. Bank Ltd.) a Co-operative Bank, registered under the Co-operative Credit Societies Act (X of 1904) and registered under the Multi State Co-operative Societies Act, 2002 having its registered office at SVC Tower, Nehru Road, Vakola, Santacruz (East), Mumbai-400 055. (hereinafter referred to as **"The Bank"** for sake of brevity) is a Scheduled Multi-State Co-operative Bank having its corporate office at "SVC Tower", Nehru Road, Vakola, Santacruz (East), Mumbai-400 055 and having one of its Branch at No.666,12th Main, 3rd Block, Rajaji Nagar, Bangalore - 560 010 (hereinafter referred to as **"Rajajinagar Branch"**) here by issue the following notice under section 13(2) of the SARFAESI ACT, 2002 to you No.1 the Borrower and you no 2 being the Builder.
You No.1 have approached Rajajinagar Branch in 2025 for Housing Loan of Rs.79,20,000/- (Rupees Seventy Nine Lakh Twenty Thousand Only) for House Purchase and accordingly made an application. The Bank has considered your request and sanctioned the following credit facility of Rs.79,20,000/- (Rupees Seventy Nine Lakh Twenty Thousand Only) to You vide Sanction Letter Ref No.SVC/BNG/RJN/ASA/113/2025-26, dated 23.06.2025 against security of the below mentioned property and execution of tripartite agreement between you No.1, 2 and the Bank.

Facility	Security	Margin	Limit (Rs.)	Remarks
Housing Loan 30000500 0018269	SCHEDULE "A" PROPERTY (Description of the entire land Area) ALL THAT PIECE AND PARCEL of the property bearing Site No.79A, layout shown as "Kammanahally village-Bannerghatta Road Layout", formed by the Central Excise House Building Co-operative Society Ltd., Bangalore, situated at KAMMANAHALLY VILLAGE, Bannerghatta road, Begur Hobli, Bangalore South, formed in Sy.Nos. 126/1, 126/2, 126/3, 126/3-1, 127, 128/2, 3 and 4 and 131/3, and coming under the limits of Bruhatth Bangalore Mahanagara Palike, Ward No.192-Begur, Bangalore, measuring East to West 60-0 ft., and North to South 41-0 ft., totally measuring 2460 sq.ft., and bounded on the East by: Site No.95A, West by: Road, North by: Site No.79, South by: Private Property. SCHEDULE "B" PROPERTY (undivided share on which security interest is created) 307 Sq.ft. of Undivided Share , right, title and interest in the Schedule "A" Property hereby conveyed by the Vendors to the Purchaser. SCHEDULE "C" PROPERTY (undivided share on which security interest is created) ALL THAT PIECE AND PARCEL of the Flat bearing No. 202, Second Floor, of the building known as "ZURICH CHALET" constructed on the Schedule A Property, having a super built-up Area measuring 1050 square feet , having RCC Roofing, vitrified Tiles Floors, Sal Wood Doors & Aluminium windows, and Separate Electricity connections, Common Water and Sanitation, including common area rights with One Covered Car parking slot in still floor, and including all rights, privileges, appurtenances thereto and Bounded on East by: Flat No. 201 West by: Set Back North by: Corridor South by: Set Back.	10%.	Rs. 79,20,000/- (Rupees Seventy Nine Lakh Twenty Thousand Only)	ROI: @8.50% p.a (i.e. PLR-12.70%) floating) to be repaid in 240 months by EMI of Rs. 68,732/- per month

You No.1 executed the necessary security documents to secure the repayment of the loan facilities that are due and payable in the aforementioned loan account. You No.2 being the builder of the property entered into tripartite agreement between Bank and You No.1. Accordingly you No.2 executed tripartite agreement and promised to pay the amount paid as loan by the Bank along with 18% interest in the event of default of payment of EMI by the borrower. The Manager and other staff members of the Rajajinagar Branch and other officers of the Bank have repeatedly requested you all to pay the outstanding amount and to ensure that the account does not become a Non-Performing Asset, but you wilfully and unjustifiably failed to pay heed to the innumerable requests made to you all from time to time and as a result of which your above mentioned account have become **Non Performing Asset (NPA)** on **20.04.2026** and have now been Classified as a **"Sub Standard Asset"**.
The Bank would like to inform you that the total amount due on **20.04.2026** is **Rs.72,34,867.64 (Rupees Seventy Two Lakh Thirty Four Thousand Eight Hundred Sixty Seven and paise Sixty Four Only)** plus contracted interest thereon from 23.04.2026 till closure along with legal & incidental expenses.
The details of which are as under:

A/c. No.	Sanctioned Limit (Rs.)	Balance Outstanding as on 22.04.2026 (Rs.)	Interest Receivable as on 22.04.2026 (Rs.)	Total Liability as on 22.04.2026 (Rs.)
300005000018269	79,20,000.00	70,50,459.00	1,84,408.64	72,34,867.64

*The Rate of Interest charged to the said term loan account is as follows:

EFFECTIVE DATE	ROI
25.06.2025	8.50 % p.a.
01.12.2025	8.30 % p.a.

By virtue of the documents duly executed by you the charge has been created in favour of the Bank on the following secured asset:
SECURITY DETAILS
SCHEDULE "A" PROPERTY (Description of the entire land Area) **ALL THAT PIECE AND PARCEL** of the property bearing Site No.79A, layout shown as "Kammanahally village-Bannerghatta Road Layout", formed by the Central Excise House Building Co-operative Society Ltd., Bangalore, situated at KAMMANAHALLY VILLAGE, Bannerghatta road, Begur Hobli, Bangalore South, formed in Sy.Nos. 126/1, 126/2, 126/3, 126/3-1, 127, 128/2, 3 and 4 and 131/3, and coming under the limits of Bruhatth Bangalore Mahanagara Palike, Ward No.192-Begur, Bangalore, measuring East to West 60-0 ft., and North to South 41-0 ft., totally measuring 2460 sq.ft., and bounded on the **East** by: Site No.95A, **West** by: Road, **North** by: Site No.79, **South** by: Private Property.
SCHEDULE "B" PROPERTY (undivided share on which security interest is created) **307 Sq.ft. of Undivided Share**, right, title and interest in the Schedule "A" Property hereby conveyed by the Vendors to the Purchaser.
SCHEDULE "C" PROPERTY (undivided share on which security interest is created) **ALL THAT PIECE AND PARCEL of the Flat bearing No. 202, Second Floor, of the building known as "ZURICH CHALET"** constructed on the Schedule A Property, having a **super built-up Area measuring 1050 square feet**, having RCC Roofing, vitrified Tiles Floors, Sal Wood Doors & Aluminium windows, and Separate Electricity connections, Common Water and Sanitation, including common area rights with **One Covered Car parking** slot in still floor, and including all rights, privileges, appurtenances thereto and Bounded on **East** by: Flat No. 201 **West** by: Set Back **North** by: Corridor **South** by: Set Back.
The Bank hereby informs you all that, under Sub-Section (13) of Section 13 of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (Hereinafter referred to as the Act) you shall after receipt of this notice refrain from either transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise create third party interest (other than in the ordinary course of business) in the above mentioned secured asset, without prior written consent of the Bank.
In view of the above the Bank hereby issues this notice under Sub-section (2) of the Section 13 of the Act and calls upon you all to pay, a sum of **Rs.72,34,867.64 (Rupees Seventy Two Lakh Thirty Four Thousand Eight Hundred Sixty Seven and paise Sixty Four Only)** as on 22.04.2026 together with contractual interest and legal & other incidental expenses with future interest prevailing from time to time from 23.04.2026 onwards until the date of payment, **within 60 days** of receipt of this notice, failing which the Bank shall be constrained to attach, sell and/or take all actions as envisaged in Sub- section (4) of section 13 of the Act and/or adopt any other legal proceeding against all of you before the competent Court / Authority including before Hon'ble Debt Recovery Tribunal which please note.
Please note that your attention is hereby invited to the provisions of sub section (8) of section 13 of the SARFAESI Act, 2002 in respect of time available to you to redeem the secured assets.
Please note that this demand notice is without prejudice to and shall not be construed as waiver of any other rights or remedies which we may have, including without limitations, the right to make further demands in respect of sums owing to us.
please note that you no.2 being the party to the tripartite agreement and builder is bound to pay the amount paid to you by the bank along with interest at 18% per annum as per clause 16 Of tripartite agreement dated 24.06.2025
FOR SVC CO-OPERATIVE BANK LIMITED, (Mr. SARATHY SOMIAH) SD/-, AUTHORIZED OFFICER & DEPUTY GENERAL MANAGER

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two separate fire incidents were reported in Delhi within hours of each other, with a blaze at a paying guest accommodation building in northwest Delhi's Mukherjee Nagar area late Sunday night leaving one woman student injured, and a minor fire breaking out at the School of Planning and Architecture campus in central Delhi on Monday morning, though no injuries or property damage were reported in the second incident.
In the first incident, the Delhi Fire Service received a call at 10:29 pm on Sunday about a fire at a ground-plus-three-storey building in Indira Vihar, Mukherjee Nagar. Five fire tenders were immediately rushed to the spot. The fire began on the ground floor, where electrical items
doused the blaze.
The second fire broke out on Monday morning at the School of Planning and Architecture campus on Vikas Marg in the ITO area of central Delhi. The Delhi Fire Service received a call at 9:37 am, following which eight fire tenders were dispatched to the location. The flames were brought under control within an hour.
The incident initially caused some confusion when the DFS described the fire as having broken out on the second floor of a Ministry of Education office. The Ministry of Education subsequently clarified that its offices are located at Kartavya Bhavan-2 on Dr Rajendra Prasad Road and have no connection to the fire. The blaze, the ministry confirmed, occurred at the SPA campus at Indraprastha Estate, Vikas Marg, which is a separate location.

The Pioneer
Classified
CHANGE OF NAME

I, Raj Pal Father of No. 16029968W LNK Dileep Kumar, R/o- Vill- Lakhmipur, PO- Pawans, Teh&Dist- Etah U.P. 207001, have changed my name from Raj Pal to Rajpal Singh, vide affidavit dated 01/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1233)/C
I, Vasdev Singh Father of- JC- 473441M Nb/Sub Banbaree Singh, R/o- Vill- Nagla Kalan Ajan, PO- Ajan, Teh- Kumher, Dist- Bharatpur, Rajasthan- 321025, have changed my name from Vasdev Singh to Basadev Singh, vide affidavit dated 01/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1234)/C
I, Sarswati Devi Mother of- JC- 473441M Nb/Sub Banbaree Singh, R/o- Vill- Nagla Kalan Ajan, PO- Ajan, Teh- Kumher, Dist- Bharatpur, Rajasthan- 321025, have changed my name from Sarswati Devi to Sarbati Devi, vide affidavit dated 01/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1235)/C
I, Surinder Kaur Mother of No.10136564A Hav Jagrup Singh, R/o- Vill- Thakkar Sandhu, PO- Dehriwal Daroga, Dist- Gurdaspur, Punjab- 143518, have changed my name from Surinder Kaur to Savinder Kaur, vide affidavit dated 01/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1236)/C
I, Virama Devi Mother of- No.15681806F Hav Bankey Bihari Gaur, R/o- Vill & PO- Parkham Gurjar, Teh- Chhata, Dist- Mathura, U.P.- 281406, have changed my name from Virama Devi to Birama, vide affidavit dated 01/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1237)/C

Baba Farid University of Health Science
Sadiq Road, Faridkot-151203 Ph. 01639-256232, 256236

E-Tender Notice
Online bids are invited through the e-tendering process for procurement of the following services/ items through the E-Procurement portal of the Government of Punjab.
Last date for submission of online bids of following tender's is 19-06-2026
1) Providing Outsourced Manpower Services for The Class IV Staff, Mail and Drivers. 2) Procurement of Books in physical and e forms for University Library, College Library and Departmental Libraries. 3) Procure of Sound System, Display 75" and 43" setup of Model Classrooms. 4) UVVC Trolley 5) RC for Autoclave. 6) Suction Machine. 7) Providing Online Counselling Services.
Last date for submission of online bids of following tender's is 29-06-2026
1) Procurement of Book Stacks for University Library.
2) Implants Material
E-tenders are invited for the procurement of following item with pre bid meeting upto 25-06-2026
1) Cardiology Implants
Note:- Tender Document can be downloaded from <http://eproc.punjab.gov.in> and www.bfhhs.ac.in
REGISTRAR
3108/12/2026-27/11779 Dated CHD : 01/06/2026

The Pioneer
Classified
CHANGE OF NAME

I, Raj Pal Father of No. 16029968W LNK Dileep Kumar, R/o- Vill- Lakhmipur, PO- Pawans, Teh&Dist- Etah U.P. 207001, have changed my name from Raj Pal to Rajpal Singh, vide affidavit dated 01/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1233)/C
I, Vasdev Singh Father of- JC- 473441M Nb/Sub Banbaree Singh, R/o- Vill- Nagla Kalan Ajan, PO- Ajan, Teh- Kumher, Dist- Bharatpur, Rajasthan- 321025, have changed my name from Vasdev Singh to Basadev Singh, vide affidavit dated 01/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1234)/C
I, Sarswati Devi Mother of- JC- 473441M Nb/Sub Banbaree Singh, R/o- Vill- Nagla Kalan Ajan, PO- Ajan, Teh- Kumher, Dist- Bharatpur, Rajasthan- 321025, have changed my name from Sarswati Devi to Sarbati Devi, vide affidavit dated 01/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1235)/C
I, Surinder Kaur Mother of No.10136564A Hav Jagrup Singh, R/o- Vill- Thakkar Sandhu, PO- Dehriwal Daroga, Dist- Gurdaspur, Punjab- 143518, have changed my name from Surinder Kaur to Savinder Kaur, vide affidavit dated 01/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1236)/C
I, Virama Devi Mother of- No.15681806F Hav Bankey Bihari Gaur, R/o- Vill & PO- Parkham Gurjar, Teh- Chhata, Dist- Mathura, U.P.- 281406, have changed my name from Virama Devi to Birama, vide affidavit dated 01/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1237)/C

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that my brother, the late Himanshu Devarari S/o Shri Tika Ram Devarari, R/o D403, Civitech Sampreeti, Sector 77, Noida, U.P. - 201301 has passed away. I, Jyoti Devarari Mayekar, I am now his sole surviving legal heir. Should anyone have any objection, they are requested to contact the Noida Authority or reach out at the address provided above--along with supporting evidence within 15 days of the publication of this notice (+91 9289816866).

Public Notice

General Public is hereby informed that my client, Sh. Surender Pal S/o Sunwari Lal and Smt. Parmila W/o Surender Pal, R/o U-11/493, Prem Nagar kirari Suleman Nagar North West Delhi, Delhi-110086 have severed all relations with their son Sh. Abhishek and his wife Mrs. Sakshi S/o Surender Pal due to his conduct and activities being against our wishes. My client hereby disown and debar him from all their movable and immovable properties. They shall have no concern, right, title or interest in any of their properties. Any person dealing with the said Sh. Abhishek and his wife Mrs. Sakshi shall do so at his/her own risk and responsibility. My client shall not be liable for any act, deed, transaction or liability incurred by him.
Vandana (Advocate) Office : 2nd floor, Library Rohini District Courts, Delhi.

Public Notice

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri Indrajit Singh to inform the public at large that Shri Indrajit Singh is purchasing the Residential Plot No. 27 area measuring 50 Sq. Yds. (out of 100 Sq. Yds.) out of Kharsa no. 559 Situated in the colony Known as Mohan Garden Extension in the area of Village Nawada Mazara Hastal Delhi State Delhi from Mrs. Kavita Sharma who became owner through GPA, ATS AND WILL dated 06/04/1989, duly attested with the Notary Public and witnessed by Mrs. Kanta Rani same to be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., So, to comply the requirements of SAHKBIFRC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/ interest/creating mortgage over the said property, shall inform the undersigned within 7 days below, along with his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of claims/interests/lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP, N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 911-0463516 & 41657372

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that M/s Koshier Construction Pvt. Ltd are the owner of the Residential Plot area measuring 1499.78 Sq. Yds, out of Kharsa no. 102M, situated in Village Sadiq Pur alias Kallipura Pargana Dasna Tehsil and Dist. Ghaziabad, U.P. through Sale Deed dated 04.05.2026 doc. no. 5734 executed by M/s Mode Properties Pvt. Ltd through its authorized signatory Mr. Mukesh Kumar in favour of M/s Koshier Construction Pvt. Ltd through its director Mr. Rajeev Kumar Malik in respect of said Property. M/s Koshier Construction Pvt. Ltd. are in the process of mortgaging the said property with Hero Fincorp Limited. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client. If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-day period by contacting Lav Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. Landline: +9102-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

Public Notice

It is informed to public at large by my client SBI Home Loan Centre South Ex-01 New Delhi through its Authorized representative Mr. Karan Singh S/o Sh. Bikha Ram, That in pursuance of a home loan A/C no. 65255279679 of Sh. Mohit Agarwal and Smt. Vasrsha Agarwal original sub lease deed executed by Noida and M/s MPG Realty Pvt Ltd in favour of Sh.Mohit Agarwal and Smt. Vasrsha Agarwal registered as document no.7052 in book no.1 vol no. 5843 on pages 209-248 on 23.04.2016 of the property bearing Flat No. F-12A04, 13TH Floor, Tower-F, Anjara Daffodil Plot No. GH07/B, Sector-137, Noida has been lost/misplaced and are untraceable. The FIR/ Lost report to this effect has already been lodged dated 30.05.2026 with LR No. 337603/2026. Any Person(s)/ company(ies)/authority(ies)/society(ies)/organisation(s)/ financial institution(s)/bank(s) claiming any right/interest having any objection or found in possession of the original document may write/contact to the above name and address within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice, post expiration Any claim(s) or objection(s) if raised or received shall be treated as null & void and such claims.
Nitin Sharma (Advocate)
Ch. No. K-67B, Near Teshil Building, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi-110054, M.: 9999990868

Cabinet hikes crop loss aid to ₹75,000 per hectare for farmers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Cabinet has approved a sharp increase in compensation for farmers whose crops were destroyed by heavy rainfall and water-logging during August and September 2025, with the Government announcing ex gratia assistance of ₹75,000 per hectare for affected agricultural land.

The decision, cleared in a Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, is expected to benefit nearly 10,000 farmers across the Capital. The Government has also approved the disbursement of around ₹33.32 crore as enhanced relief assistance.

Officials said crops spread across nearly 10,977 acres, or about 4,442 hectares, were damaged after prolonged rainfall and overflowing natural drains inundated farmlands in several parts of Delhi last year.

The revised compensation marks a substantial increase from the earlier assistance rate that had been in place since 2015. Under the previous arrangement, farmers were entitled to ₹20,000 per acre,



which worked out to around ₹49,421 per hectare. The Government said the revised rate was introduced after considering rising agricultural costs over the past decade.

The Chief Minister said the Government had taken the decision to provide stronger financial support to farmers facing losses caused by extreme weather conditions. She said the assistance would help affected farmers recover financially and prepare for the next agricultural cycle. The Government, she added, considered protection of farmers' livelihoods and agricultural stability a priority.

According to the Government, a detailed assessment carried out by the Revenue Department

found that crop losses in the affected regions were complete due to continuous rainfall and severe waterlogging. Based on the assessment, the Cabinet approved compensation at the full rate of ₹75,000 per hectare.

Earlier rules allowed proportional compensation for losses up to 70 percent, while full assistance was granted only when damage exceeded that level. Officials said the latest assessment recorded crop destruction at 100 percent in several affected areas.

The Government clarified that the assistance would be limited to recorded landowners. Land owned by companies, Gram Sabha land, and farmhouse plots enclosed by permanent boundary walls

will not qualify for compensation under the scheme.

The Chief Minister said the decision was linked specifically to the damage caused during the August-September 2025 rainfall period and the disruption of the natural drainage system that led to widespread flooding in agricultural fields.

She said Governments must stand with farmers during natural disasters and periods of distress. The Chief Minister also referred to the Centre's efforts to increase farm incomes and strengthen support systems for cultivators during crises.

Officials said the enhanced relief would ensure quicker recovery for affected farmers and reduce pressure on families dependent on agriculture for their livelihoods.

The Cabinet decision comes at a time when concerns over climate-related disruptions and erratic weather patterns are increasingly affecting agricultural production in and around the national Capital.

Waterlogging and inadequate drainage remain recurring problems in low-lying rural belts of Delhi during periods of heavy rainfall.

Government shifts 40 CPA officers, including 10 doctors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Monday transferred 40 medical, paramedical, and administrative officers and employees working under the Central Procurement Agency (CPA) operating under the Department of Health and Family Welfare of the Health Department.

In a press statement, the chief minister's office stated that 10 doctors, including HOO (Head of Office) Dr Vinod Kumar Ranga, have been transferred in the CPA. Apart from this, 19 employees have been transferred to strengthen paramedical services. This includes pharmacists, junior medical lab technicians, lab attendants, drivers, etc.

According to Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, to increase efficiency in administrative works, 10 employees of Section Officer, Senior Assistant, and Junior Assistant levels have also been transferred. During the review of human resources, the status of officers and employees working in the CPA has also been assessed.

Along with this, information on such employees has also been compiled who are on the pay scale of CPA but are working in other



offices, so that more effective utilization of available resources can be ensured. Apart from this, other staff has also been removed from the CPA.

The Chief Minister made it clear that any kind of negligence or indiscipline will not be tolerated in this.

The Chief Minister informed that CPA is an important center of the Delhi Government's health system, from where the work of procurement and supply of medicines, medical equipment, and other essential health materials is operated.

To make this system more efficient, experienced officers and employees from various hospitals and departments are being

attached. Under this process, 12 medical officers from various hospitals and health institutions have been posted to the CPA. These include Senior Medical Officer, Medical Officer, and CMO level officers. Their posting will further strengthen procurement, storage, supply, and administrative works.

The Chief Minister said that to expedite departmental works, additional responsibilities have also been assigned to various officers. The responsibility of operating the Project Branch, Caretaking Branch, Store and Purchase Branch, Computer Cell, Mobile Health Scheme, PGMS, RTI, Child Rights, Health Mela, Hospital Coordination, and

other important units has been given to the respective officers. Apart from this, necessary administrative arrangements have also been made to make the works related to the Store and Purchase Branch and CPA more effective.

She said that the objective of the Delhi Government is to provide the necessary human resources to every unit of the Health Department and to strengthen the institutional capacity and her Government is committed to ensuring that the procurement and supply system of medicines and medical materials is fully strengthened and better and time-bound health services are available to the residents of Delhi.

Saket collapse: Students lose study gear after rushed escape

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

After the Saket building collapse, killing six people, students in the area have been dealing with trauma, uncertainty, and the loss of important study materials left inside a nearby building now sealed by authorities. The aftermath of the collapse continues to impact daily life for many.

In particular, students at Arise Medical Academy, located next to the collapsed building, said they had to leave behind books, notes, tablets, iPads, and other devices during the rushed evacuation after the collapse around 7 pm on Saturday. "We panicked and rushed out, leaving all our study materials. If the building becomes unstable, everything could be lost said a student preparing for the Foreign Medical Graduate Examination (FMGE).

"Our exam is on June 28. Given this urgency, we urge authorities to let us in and retrieve our study materials immediately, the student added. It felt like an earthquake. The chairs shook, and the lights went out. For a moment, we thought we wouldn't make it, said



Work to clear the debris is underway at the site where the building collapsed at Saket in New Delhi on Monday

PANKAJ KUMAR

another student, adding that about 150 students were present.

Thankfully, the staircase was wide enough for us to evacuate quickly. But those responsible must be held accountable, he added.

For many students, the loss of access to study materials just a month before exams has worsened stress and anxiety. Adding to their distress, a broader concern now centres on the structural safety of buildings in the locality, many of which are old and allegedly poorly maintained.

This anxiety is shared by others in the community. Nitesh Kumar, who studied with one of the victims, Alok Verma, said that repeated concerns about building con-

ditions in the area have not been addressed.

"My building is over 20 years old and not properly maintained. We've raised concerns, but nothing has been done. Authorities must inspect every building and act before more lives are lost, Kumar said.

Many buildings here don't seem structurally sound. We urge authorities to identify unsafe buildings and take prompt action; she said.

As rescue efforts continue and investigations move forward, both residents and students say the tragedy has brought to light long-standing concerns about building safety in one of the city's busiest education hubs, reinforcing the urgent need for preventive measures.

I&FC department tapped to boost Yamuna water flow amid crisis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has roped in the irrigation and flood control (I&FC) department to improve the flow of Yamuna water, officials said on Monday. For the past several days, the city has been facing severe water shortage, affecting supply in several parts of the Capital.

"The supply has improved slightly since last week. We are using I&FC department machines to make channels in the pond near Wazirabad so that maximum water reaches our pumps," a senior DJB officer said.



According to officials, the equipment is being used to dig through accumulated silt at the Wazirabad water treatment plant (WTP).

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday said the Haryana Government has assured

maintaining 1,000 cusecs of water supply through the Munak Canal.

According to officials, the current water supply stands around 912 million gallons per day (MGD) against the target of 1,002 MGD.

June starts coolest in 3 years as max temp hits 36.3°C

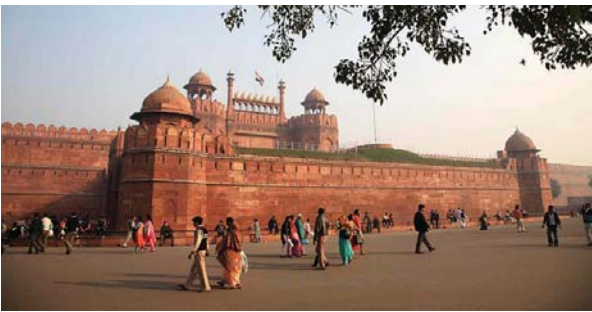
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The national Capital on Monday experienced below-normal maximum temperatures on the first day of June, marking the coolest start to the month in three years, with the Safdarjung observatory, the official marker for the city, logging 36.3 degrees Celsius.

The maximum temperature reached 36.3 degrees Celsius, while the minimum temperature was recorded at 24.9 degrees Celsius.

The last time the city recorded a lower maximum temperature on June 1 was in 2023, when it stood at 32.7 degrees Celsius, while the minimum temperature was 20.6 degrees Celsius.

The India Meteorological Department's (IMD) data showed that the maximum was 3.7 degrees below the seasonal norm at Safdarjung. Palam recorded 35.5 degrees, which was 5.5 degrees below normal. Other stations followed a similar trend: Lodi Road 35.2



degrees, Ridge 35.6 degrees, and Ayanagar 35.4 degrees.

Compared to the previous day, maximum temperatures

rose slightly by 0.5 to 1.0 degree across most stations. The minimum temperatures also remained below normal,

ranging between 22.2 and 24.9 degrees.

No rainfall was recorded in the last 24 hours or during the day across any of the five monitoring stations.

According to IMD officials, no alerts have been issued, but there is a chance of a partly cloudy sky becoming generally cloudy. A spell of very light to light rain is likely, accompanied by thunderstorm/lightning and strong winds of 40-50 kmph, gusting up to 60 kmph, during the afternoon/evening.

84 flats planned for judicial officers in Shahdara at ₹200 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government plans to construct 84 residential flats for judicial officers at Central Business District, Shahdara at an estimated cost of ₹200 crore.

The Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation (DTTDC) has invited consultants for comprehensive architectural design and engineering planning services for the project, comprising staff quarters for judicial officers on a one-hectare plot in east Delhi, according to the



tender document.

The proposed residential complex will have accommodation for 36 district judges and 48 civil judges. The plinth area for the residential accommodation of each unit shall be 2,500 square feet for

district judge (36) and 2,000 square feet for civil judge (48), it said.

The project has been entrusted to DTTDC by the law department after approval from the Delhi Government. Land for the project, measur-

ing one hectare or around 10,000 square metres, has already been allotted by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) and handed over to the law department, according to the document.

The selected consultant will be responsible for preparing concept plans, detailed project reports, architectural and structural drawings, obtaining statutory approvals from agencies including the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Delhi Fire Department and Delhi Urban Art Commission, and assisting in execution of the project, it said.

23,000 rooftop plants boost solar output to 420 MW

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi's solar footprint has expanded to over 23,000 rooftop plants, generating 420 MW of power, enough to cover daily energy needs of around two lakh households and institutions, discom officials said on Monday.

The BSES discoms in the city — BRPL and BYPL — have energised more than 13,600 rooftop solar connections with around 260 MWP (Megawatt peak) load, a company spokesperson said. Megawatt peak refers to

power output from sources such as solar and wind energy depending on sunlight and wind speed, respectively. The rooftop solar is helping BSES consumers to save nearly ₹200 crore annually, said the company spokesperson.

Around 4,600 rooftop solar connections were energised in 2025-26, the highest ever in a year. These included more than 2,600 connections under the PM Surya Ghar scheme.

The total PM Surya Ghar scheme connection energised by the BSES discoms



have gone upto over 4100 now, he stated.

The highest rooftop solar connections are in domestic (9,888), followed by commercial (2,184), educational (1,009), others (342) and industrial (207) categories, he said. A major catalyst behind

the sharp rise has been the subsidies under Central Government's 'PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana', and Delhi Solar Policy, totalling Rs 1.08 lakh that has significantly improved affordability for residential consumers, officials said.

For a typical household, a 5 kW rooftop solar system can potentially deliver savings of ₹3,500 or more per month, depending on consumption levels and tariff slab. Further, the surplus power is sold to the discoms at DERC-determined prices, officials said.

Susan Elias takes charge as first woman Principal of St Stephen's college , defying Delhi University

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Susan Elias assumed charge as the 14th principal of St. Stephen's College on Monday, becoming the first woman to lead the institution in its 145-year history. The joining development happened amidst the long-running governance dispute between the college and Delhi University, which had formally asked the college not to proceed with the appointment on the grounds that the selection process violated UGC regulations.

When *The Pioneer* reached out to Elias on her joining day for a comment, she declined

to respond, saying she was unavailable. The college had announced her appointment through a notification issued on May 12, with an effective date of June 1.

Despite Delhi University's written directive asking the college to halt the process, St Stephen's proceeded as planned, relying on its minority institution status under Article 30(1) of the Constitution and a 2008 Delhi High Court judgment that held the college was not bound by Delhi University Ordinance provisions governing the constitution of selection committees for principals.

Delhi University had argued that the selection committee constituted for Elias's appointment did not comply with norms laid down by the University Grants Commission.

Under UGC Regulations 2018, the panel should have included university-nominated experts and a nominee of the Vice-Chancellor.

The university also approached the UGC seeking intervention. Both directions were effectively set aside by the college when it proceeded with the appointment.

Elias is a computer scientist and academic administrator with over three decades of



experience in higher education. She has held leadership roles at institutions including Chandigarh University and VIT Chennai,

and has worked extensively in artificial intelligence and emerging technologies.

Her appointment as principal succeeds John Varghese,

whose tenure became a flashpoint in the broader DU-St. Stephen's dispute. Delhi University had repeatedly challenged Varghese's continuation in the principal's position beyond March 2021, describing his extension as illegal and non-statutory.

More recently, DU also wrote to the college, asking it not to appoint Varghese as a professor in the English Department, calling any such move ultra vires the UGC rules and university regulations. Varghese's name has since appeared on the college's English Department webpage, though the Principal's page remains empty.

The 2008 Delhi High Court precedent that the college is now relying upon arose during the appointment of former principal Valson Thampu. In that ruling, the court held that St. Stephen's, as a minority educational institution, was not bound by the relevant provisions of the Delhi University Ordinance relating to the constitution of principal selection committees.

Even after that judgment, Thampu's formal recognition by the university came significantly later, and his salary was initially drawn not from UGC funds but from the college's private resources.

College officials have indicated Elias's situation may follow a similar trajectory.

Founded in 1881, St Stephen's has historically maintained that its status as a minority institution grants it meaningful autonomy in matters of governance and appointments.

Delhi University's position is that UGC regulations apply regardless of that status.

With Elias now in charge, the dispute is likely to move further through legal and administrative channels. The college has taken the first step. What DU and the UGC do next will determine how the standoff develops.

IN FOCUS



Workers working in a paddy field as paddy transplantation begins across the region near Amritsar, Punjab

PTI

UP CM Yogi calls cow *Rashtra Mata*, slams clerics

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bijnor

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Monday hit out at Muslim clerics and organisations for demanding that the cow be declared the national animal, saying the cow is revered as “mother” in the Sanatan tradition and is “not an animal for us”.

“Your thinking is animal-like if you describe Gau Mata as an animal,” Adityanath said while addressing an event here.

“The cow is our mother. She is not merely an animal. Your mindset is animalistic if you call our Gau Mata an animal.... Gau Mata is our ‘Rashtra Mata’. It does not require any formal declaration... just as we respect our own mother... and the Ganga,” he said.

The chief minister referred to recent demands by Jamiat Ulema-e-Hind president Maulana Arshad Madani and some other Muslim groups for granting the cow the status of national animal



CM Yogi listenin to people's grievances during Janata Darshan in Lucknow

PTI

and said their remarks reek of hypocrisy as these very people “promote cow slaughter”.

“Nowadays, many maulvis and maulanas are demanding that the cow be declared the national animal. We say that the cow is our mother and our bond with her extends across lifetimes,” the

chief minister said, asserting that the cow occupies a revered position in Sanatan tradition.

“Those making such demands were displaying double standards as, on the one hand, they are seeking recognition for the cow while on the other, they are supporting cow slaughter.”

The chief minister said that “there was no need for ‘akranta’ (invaders) to teach about the status of the cow”.

“We have our own values and traditions. We have always regarded the cow as a mother,” he said, adding that the cow was already a “self-declared Rashtra Mata” and did not require formal recognition from anyone.

Adityanath was addressing a function organised for the distribution of land ownership certificates to 1,645 displaced families from Pakistan and to ex-servicemen and land allottees.

The chief minister also criticised Muslim clerics for what he described as their silence on the plight of religious minorities in neighbouring countries.

He alleged that no prominent Muslim religious leader had spoken up for people displaced from Pakistan and Bangladesh due to religious persecution or raised concerns about the declining population of Hindus in

Pakistan, Bangladesh and Afghanistan. The chief minister claimed that if religious leaders had offered land allegedly held under waqf properties for the rehabilitation of displaced families, it would have demonstrated genuine sensitivity towards their suffering.

Referring to social media posts during the recent Eid-ul-Azha festival, Adityanath alleged that supporters of some clerics had shared images of cows while extending greetings.

“I want to tell them that they should rein in such elements or their generations will remember the consequences if any harm is done to Gau Mata”.

He said the state government’s proactive measures had ensured that festivals and religious events were conducted peacefully.

he chief minister also referred to a recent murder case in Ghaziabad in which a youth was allegedly stabbed to death by his friend on Eid.

45.31 lakh have registered for Char Dham, Hemkund yatras

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dehradun

More than 45.31 lakh devotees have registered for the annual Char Dham and Hemkund Sahib yatra so far, officials said on Monday.

According to officials, total registrations across the five pilgrimage sites have reached 45,31,080. Kedarnath Dham recorded the highest number of registrations with nearly 14.87 lakh pilgrim enrolments, followed by Badrinath with 13.48 lakh. Registrations for Gangotri stood at 8.06 lakh, while Yamunotri recorded



around 7.78 lakh enrolments. Hemkund Sahib registered nearly 1.11 lakh pilgrims.

On Monday, physical registration centres recorded 25,568 devotees singing up offline. The Rishikesh Transit Camp logged the highest daily turnout with 11,492 registrations, followed by Haridwar with 11,357.

Fake signature row: CID serves second summons to Abhishek

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

CID sleuths visited TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee’s residence on Monday evening for the second time in just over 48 hours in connection with a signature forgery case and served him another notice for appearance before investigators on June 8, sources said.

He has been directed to appear at the CID headquarters, Bhabani Bhavan, for questioning in the case of alleged use of fake signatures of party MLAs in a communication to the Assembly speaker, endorsing



Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay’s selection as the Leader of Opposition (LoP).

This came after he avoided an appearance before the CID on Monday and sought two weeks’ time, citing health reasons, after

the agency summoned him in connection with the probe. “Dada (Abhishek Banerjee) has signed and received the appearance notice. He will decide on the next course of action,” Ayan Ghosh, an employee with Banerjee’s office, told reporters outside his residence after the sleuths left.

The CID team reached the TMC MP’s residence around 5.30 pm and recorded videos of the premises as part of its probe, an officer of the investigating agency said. “The videography is being conducted to document the premises and collect evidence,” he said.

“The inquiry is progressing in accordance with the law. Necessary statements and materials linked to the case are being examined.”

The CID took over the probe into the signature forgery case from Kolkata Police on May 28, a day after the Hare Street police station registered a case based on a complaint from the principal secretary of the state assembly with charges of cheating, forgery and criminal conspiracy.

The probe agency has, so far, questioned 13 TMC MLAs in connection with the case.

The complaint was lodged after two TMC MLAs

— Ritabrata Banerjee and Sandipan Saha – informed Speaker Rathindra Bose on May 27 that “no resolution was adopted about the selection of LoP” in the party’s May 6 meeting.

The two MLAs alleged that the so-called May 6 resolution was “manufactured and fabricated” and stated that as many as 14 of the 70 signatures were in “block letters”.

On Monday, the TMC expelled both MLAs from the party for alleged “anti-party activities”, minutes after Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari publicly revealed their names.

Six of JEE top 10 rank holders emerge from single institute in Kota

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kota

Kota-based Allen Career Institute on Monday claimed that six of the top 10 rank holders in the JEE (Advanced) 2026 results were its students.

The institute said 24 of its students featured in the top 50 rank, while 41 secured places in the top 100.

According to Allen’s founder director Rajesh Maheshwari, Shubham Kumar from the institute emerged as the all India topper with a score of 330 out of 360, followed by Kabi Chillar with 329 marks, and Jatin Chahar with 319 marks.

The institute also said that Arohi Deshpande was the all-India girls’ topper, securing AIR 77 with 280 marks. The Allen institute further claimed that five of the seven IIT zonal toppers, covering Delhi, Guwahati, Kanpur, Bhubaneswar and Roorkee, were its students.

Allen CEO Nitin Kukreja told PTI, “It’s a hat-trick. This is the third time that an AIR-1 has come from Allen. No other institute has performed so well in the last 10 years.” “We are happy and proud of the successes of each and every student of the institute,” he said. “Expert faculties, 38-year-old pedagogy and legacy of Allen Career Institute, strong digital support and academic, non-academic ethos and culture of the institute are the four key factors that helped produce top rankers and create success,” he said.

Manipur: Naga apex body cancels release of 14 Kuki civilians

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Imphal/Senapati

The apex body of Naga tribes in Manipur on Monday cancelled the scheduled release of 14 Kuki civilians following disagreements with certain youth leaders and stakeholders of the tribal community.

In a statement, the United Naga Council said, “Considering the prevailing sentiments of the Naga public, the proposed release of the 14 Kuki detainees, earlier scheduled at 2 pm on June 1, hereby stands cancelled. The 14 Kuki civilians were detained and taken hostage on May 13 and were scheduled to be released on Monday afternoon before being taken to Kangpokpi district for a reception programme.

The decision to facilitate their release triggered resentment among some



Naga youth groups and civil society organisations, which alleged that the move had been taken without adequate consultation with stakeholders in the Naga-majority district, officials said. Multiple meetings were held among the Naga

civil society organisations and student bodies at Senapati for hours, where it was pointed out that the fate of six Naga civilians abducted by Kuki armed groups remains unknown, officials added.

The Naga groups pointed

out that the whereabouts and condition of the six youths held hostage must be first revealed by Kuki armed groups before finalising the release of the Kuki hostages.

In an earlier statement, the UNC had said that it, along with the Naga People’s

Organisation (NPO), Senapati, had intervened for the release of the 14 Kuki detainees held by the Naga Village Guard-Northern Command after consultations with stakeholders.

The council said the decision was influenced by appeals from the Baptist community, Naga churches, tribal bodies and organisations, as well as an assurance given by Union Home Minister Amit Shah to Nagaland Chief Minister Neiphiu Rio that the Ministry of Home Affairs would trace the abducted Naga civilians, identify those responsible and ensure legal action.

The UNC also referred to an appeal by the Manipur government and its assurance that the Suspension of Operations (SoO) ground rules would be strictly enforced, including rationalisation and relocation of camps.

FROM PAGE - 1

BJP shifts gears for Assembly, RS polls

A day earlier, on Sunday, the BJP’s Central Election Committee met to finalise candidates for the upcoming Rajya Sabha and Legislative Council elections. The meeting was chaired by BJP president Nitin Nabin and attended by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Leadership also reviewed political developments and forthcoming organisational changes in other states, with appointments already made in Delhi, Haryana, Tripura, and Punjab.

In a related development on Monday, the BJP appointed Nagendra Nath Tripathi as the party’s national organiser, a party functionary said. Tripathi, a senior BJP leader, was serving as zonal general secretary for Bihar and Jharkhand.

These meetings are part of preparations for the June 18 Rajya Sabha elections in 10 states, as scheduled by the Election Commission.

West Bengal Cabinet gets bigger

Ministers of State sworn in included Joyel Murmu, Ashok Dinda, Anandamoy Burman, Koushik Chowdhury, Gargi Das Ghosh, Bhaskar Bhattacharya, Dibakar Gharami, Sumana Sarkar, Santanu Pramanik, Purnima Chakraborty, and Umesh Rai.

Minister Nisith Pramanik, a Rajbanshi leader from Mathabhanga in Cooch Behar, is already in the Cabinet. On Monday, three new ministers from North Bengal joined: Deepak Burman from Falakata, Shankar Ghosh from Siliguri, and Manoj Kumar Oraon from Kumargram in Alipurduar.

Malati Rava Roy was appointed MoS (Independent Charge). Four others, Anandamay Burman, Bishal Lama, Koushik Chowdhury, and Biraj Biswas, were appointed as ministers of state. North Bengal now has nine ministers.

The previous TMC ministry included eight of 43 ministers from North Bengal. Adhikari’s council has slightly increased representation

from the region.

The expanded council now includes 14 ministers from various ethnic groups, with 11 from the SC and ST categories sworn in on Monday.

The BJP inducted Deepak Burman, a SC MLA from Falakata, and Manoj Kumar Oraon, a tribal leader from Kumargram in Alipurduar, into the state Cabinet.

Pramanik, a Rajbanshi leader, along with Cabinet ministers Ashok Kirtania (a Matua leader) and Kshudiram Tudu (a tribal leader), had already joined. The number of SC/ST leaders in the Cabinet is now five. Additionally, Rajesh Mahata, a leader of the SC Kudmi community from Gopiballavpur in Jhargram, West Bengal, was inducted as minister of state. Three BJP MLAs from the ST community and six from the SC group became ministers of state. There are now 15 ministers from backward castes, representing about 37 per cent of the total.

JEE Advanced qualifiers risk losing IIT...

Earlier, more than 24 lakhs students are still affected due to the cancellation of NEET exams, which is going for a re-test on June 21 amidst lots of uncertainties including a CBI probe in the entrance questions paper leak.

The JEE (Advanced) is the gateway for admission to undergraduate programmes at the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) and several other premier engineering institutions across the country. The successful candidates have to register on the Joint Seat Allocation Authority (JoSAA) portal, which begins June 2, 2026. JoSAA is the body allocating seats across IITs, NITs, IIITs, and other centrally funded technical institutions.

JoSAA admission process allows this liberty every year, but since this year, the CBSE marking system has raised eyebrows; students and parents are concerned about the evaluation of answer sheets since they have been marked quite low in the results declared in a routine way.

“We can’t expect an increase of 15 marks in every paper and even if this would be genuine

am sure CBSE will never confess the error in evaluation process,” said Amit Kumar, who’s son Rudrakash is facing similar issues.

Similar anxiety was raised by Dhruv Mishra, who is not meeting the 75 per cent base qualifying marks in CBSE 12th but was declared in the Advanced JEE results. “I toiled hard for both the class 12 as well as JEE Main and now Advanced. Don’t know where to go as the system seems to have collapsed with no one to listen to the grievances,” said Dhruv, a candidate from Jamshedpur, Jharkhand. Out of fear, Dhruv’s parents requested a name change to express their concerns.

With several students still awaiting updated marksheets in case re-evaluation is required, there is concern that delays or changes in final marks could affect eligibility or seat allocation outcomes. For some candidates, this uncertainty may impact their chances of securing their preferred course, institute, or branch of IIT.

Class 12 performance is an essential eligibility condition that can determine whether a candidate is ultimately allowed to secure an IIT seat, even after qualifying for the entrance examination.

Those going for revaluation, and if the candidate’s updated or revised result makes them eligible, they can be considered for admission at IITs, which, though, comes with a rider that the process has to be completed by July 15.

Shubham Kumar from the Delhi zone topped the IIT entrance exam JEE-Advanced with 330 out of 360 marks. A total of 56,880 candidates qualified for the Joint Entrance Examination (Advanced) 2026. Of the total qualified candidates, 10,107 are female candidates. A total of 46,773 male candidates.

Myanmar vows its territory won’t be used...

The discussions underscored the importance of strengthening bilateral cooperation, including trade and economic ties, defence and security, border management, development assistance

and cultural exchanges. Both sides noted ongoing discussions on various bilateral Agreements and Memoranda of Understanding and looked forward to their early conclusion.

PM Modi underlined that enhanced connectivity would foster mutually beneficial economic linkages and shared prosperity in the region. In this regard, both sides shared the importance of working closely towards the completion of Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand trilateral highway.

He also conveyed that the Mekong Ganga ICCR scholarships for Myanmar students would be enhanced from 36 to 100 from 2026 onwards.

The PM further reaffirmed India’s support for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the Republic of the Union of Myanmar while conveying support for the country’s efforts towards achieving peace, stability, national reconciliation and socio-economic development. He also offered continued assistance and cooperation, based on mutual respect and friendly relations between the two countries.

Trust PM, will deliver justice: Panel on NEET

Secretary (Higher Education) Vineet Joshi, Secretary (Health and Family Welfare) Punya Salila Srivastava and NTA DG Abhishek Singh were summoned by the Committee on Monday to appear before it to discuss the advantages and disadvantages of the pen and paper and the CBT systems. The NTA earlier informed the Supreme Court that NEET-UG will transition to the CBT format in 2027 to enhance examination security. The recommendation to transition to a computer-based test was made by a high-level expert committee. The meeting was also attended by top officials from the education ministry and NTA officials.

NTA officials told the panel that the agency’s complete focus for now was to hold the NEET-UG re-test on June 21 in pen-paper format, sources said. They are learnt to have told the



their home with the intention of killing him.

The prosecutor said that when Muzaffar tried to escape after the initial attack, the woman allegedly threw acid on him again. The assault left his face completely disfigured and resulted in the loss of vision in both eyes.

Yadav said the couple frequently quarrelled and that the woman was seeking a divorce, claiming that she was involved in an extra-marital relationship. The couple has two children.

panel that the NTA intends to hold the NEET exam in CBT format from 2027.

Members sought details from officials on measures being adopted to ensure a fool-proof examination process. Sources say officials informed the panel that extensive efforts were being undertaken to eliminate loopholes, including greater reliance on in-house paper setters, teachers and professors to strengthen the system.

The committee also urged authorities to adopt stringent and innovative safeguards ahead of the June 21 examination and emphasised the need for close coordination between the education ministry and the health ministry to ensure the smooth conduct of the test, the sources said.

The committee will again meet on Tuesday to review the use of the On-Screen Marking system (OSM) in CBSE board exams and issues faced by students in the wake of technical glitches.

Among the key agenda items before the committee were on financial grants and related to the use of traditional pen-and-paper examinations versus Computer-Based Testing (CBT).

Commercial LPG gets costlier

Meanwhile, the oil marketing companies (OMCs) have kept the price of aviation turbine fuel (ATF), or jet fuel, unchanged for scheduled domestic flights for the second month in a row. Additionally, relief also came for Indian carriers in the form of a 27 per cent cut in jet fuel price for international flights. With this cut, the price of jet fuel for international flights has come down to levels similar for domestic flights. For May, ATF price for domestic flights was kept unchanged, while for international flights, it was hiked by \$76.55 per kl to \$1,511.86 per kl. For June, while the price of jet fuel for domestic flights continues to be the same, for international flights, it has been cut by about \$400 per kl to around \$1,100 per kl, according to OMC sources. In rupee terms, it comes out to be around ₹1,05,000 per kl.

Bhupender Yadav rejects Jairam’s allegations over Nicobar project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav has rejected Congress leader Jairam Ramesh’s allegations that the environmental clearances granted to the Great Nicobar Island (GNI) project were based on “inadequate” baseline environmental studies and rapid assessments.

In a letter to the Congress leader, dated May 27, Yadav said that the issues raised by Ramesh had already been examined during the statutory appraisal and subsequent judicially mandated review process.

“The project was appraised through detailed environmental studies, shoreline assessments, marine investigations, and modelling exercises undertaken by a reputed institution,” said the minister.

Spread over 166 sq km, the GNI project comprises the construction of a transshipment port, an integrated township, a civil and military airport, and a 450-MVA gas and solar power-based plant. Its construction will require diverting 130.75 sq km of forest land.

In his May 10 letter to Yadav, Ramesh alleged that the baseline data collection



for the studies for the project took place over “a few days and weeks at best,” instead of collecting data over at least three months as mandated by the law for such projects.

In his response, Yadav said that these studies were undertaken by reputed institutions such as the Zoological Survey of India (ZSI), Botanical Survey of India (BSI), Salim Ali Centre for Ornithology and Natural History (SACON), and Wildlife Institute of India (WII).

All of these institutions possess extensive historical datasets and decades of ecological research experience in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, according to the minister.

“Although primary field data for the project was collected over a single seasonal cycle, the analysis integrated freshly collected data with long-term historical datasets available with these institutions, thereby ensuring that the environmental assessment and Environmental Management Plan (EMP) were scientifically robust, comprehensive and based on site-specific ecological understanding,” said Yadav.

Ramesh, in his letter, had also alleged that a major part of the shoreline of the Galathea Bay — Great Nicobar’s southern tip, where the transshipment port is to be built — is eroding.

As a result, a comprehen-

sive environmental impact assessment with cumulative studies for the project was required under the Island Coastal Regulation Zone (ICRZ) Notification, 2019, according to the Congress leader.

Yadav responded to this claim by saying that “the eastern flank of Galathea Bay, where the proposed port is located, is predominantly stable.” That’s why “comprehensive three-season studies” were not needed, the Union minister reasoned.

Ramesh had also urged Yadav to make public the report of the National Green Tribunal (NGT) mandated High-Powered Committee (HPC), tasked with revisiting the project’s environmental clearances.

Responding to the Congress leader’s demand, the minister stated that the report contains information of strategic, defence and national importance.

Therefore, certain details were treated as confidential in accordance with Section 8(1)(a) of the Right to Information Act, 2005, which exempts disclosure of information that may prejudicially affect the sovereignty, security, strategic or scientific interests of the state, according to Yadav.

CBI arrests Amitabh Jhunjhunwala in SBI loan fraud case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI on Monday arrested a former Group Managing Director of Reliance Communications, Amitabh Jhunjhunwala, in connection with the loss of ₹2,929.05 crore caused to the State Bank of India by the company in alleged loan fraud, officials said.

Jhunjhunwala, who was already in judicial custody and lodged in Jail in the national Capital in connection with an ongoing investigation by the Enforcement Directorate, was taken to Mumbai by

the CBI after production warrants were issued by a special court there, they said.

He was produced before the court, following which the CBI formally arrested him.

“He was brought to Mumbai and produced before the court on June 1, 2026. After his production, the CBI effected his formal arrest, which was taken on record by the court. Thereafter, the accused was remanded to judicial custody in the RCom case of the CBI and sent to Arthur Road Jail.

“His police custody petition will be taken up tomorrow (Tuesday),”



the CBI Spokesperson said in a statement. About his alleged role, the CBI said Jhunjhunwala was the Group Managing Director of the Reliance Communications group and was controlling important functions like corporate finance, banking, utilisation of funds, etc.

“He coordinated with senior formations of the bank for loans and advances. Based on his directions, loan funds received from the banks were managed and utilised by other officials of the Rcom group. It is alleged that due to misutilisation of loan funds, the banks suffered wrongful losses,”

the agency Spokesperson said.

The agency had registered an FIR against Reliance Communications Limited and businessman Anil Ambani for allegedly causing a loss of ₹2,929.05 crore to the State Bank of India, which was one of the 11 banks that had sanctioned term loans to the company.

“The consortium of 11 banks, led by the State Bank of India, together suffered a loss of 6015 crore. According to the complaint, the total exposure towards RCom amounted to ₹19,694.33 crore involving 17 PSU Banks,” the Spokesperson said.

ED attaches ₹1,000 cr assets in Chhattisgarh liquor scam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) said on Monday that it has attached properties with a combined market value of more than ₹1,000 crore as part of its probe into the alleged Chhattisgarh liquor scam.

The ED also said it has filed a fresh prosecution complaint against four additional accused, taking the total number of accused persons in the money laundering case to 85.

The federal agency said it issued three provisional attachment orders on May 28 under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), attaching properties with a deed value of around ₹200 crore and a combined market value exceeding ₹1,000 crore.

According to the ED, its investigation found that a liquor syndicate led by Anwar



Dhebar and retired IAS officer Anil Tuteja, in connivance with senior state officials, distillery owners and private entities, “systematically manipulated the Chhattisgarh excise machinery between 2019 and 2023” to generate proceeds of crime exceeding ₹2,883 crore.

The agency alleged that the illegal proceeds were generated through “artificial inflation of liquor procurement rates, clandestine man-

ufacture of unaccounted liquor, and extraction of commissions through FL-10A licences granted to favoured entities”.

The first attachment order pertains to properties linked to one Vikas Agrawal and Dhebar. The ED alleged that Agrawal “functioned as the ground-level financial manager of the syndicate, collecting commissions from distilleries and FL-10A licensees and routing funds directly to Anwar Dhebar”.

The agency said properties standing in the names of Agrawal’s family members have been attached as equivalent value of his alleged proceeds of crime. It also attached what it described as Dhebar’s benami properties, including plots in Raipur allegedly held through firms and shell entities under his beneficial control. The total attachment under this order is around ₹30 crore.

In a second attachment order, the ED attached Hotel Westinn Goa in North Goa, owned by Pacifica Hotels India Pvt Ltd.

The investigation, it said, established that the hotel “was acquired entirely out of proceeds of crime” for a consideration of about ₹110 crore. The agency alleged that the amount “was paid in unaccounted cash sourced from the liquor scam and physically transported at the instance of Chaitanya Baghel”.

PM Modi hails 6 years of PM SVANidhi scheme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday said the PM SVANidhi scheme supporting street vendors has transformed the lives of countless hawkers by ensuring access to collateral-free credit, financial inclusion and new opportunities for growth. On the completion of six years of the scheme,

enterprise continue to strengthen our nation’s economy,” Modi said in a post on social media.

The Prime Minister Street Vendor’s AtmaNirbhar Nidhi (PM SVANidhi) is a central sector scheme supporting street vendors through affordable working capital, financial inclusion and social protection measures.

The PM SVANidhi was



he also said that PM SVANidhi is all about trust, dignity and empowerment.

“Today we mark #6YearsofPMSVANidhi, a scheme which has transformed the lives of countless street vendors by ensuring access to collateral-free credit, financial inclusion and new opportunities for growth. This scheme is all about trust, dignity and empowerment. My best wishes to all beneficiaries whose determination and

launched during the COVID-19 pandemic to provide affordable working capital loans to street vendors whose businesses had been severely affected.

As the first dedicated micro-credit scheme for street vendors, who constituted a significant part of the informal workforce and often had limited access to formal credit, it aimed to support the growth of their businesses while promoting financial inclusion.

States Focus



CDS NS RAJA SUBRAMANI MEETS PRESIDENT MURMU

Newly appointed Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) General NS Raja Subramani on Monday called on President Droupadi Murmu at the Rashtrapati Bhavan.

The President’s office shared a picture of the meeting in a post on social media.

“Chief of Defence Staff General NS Raja Subramani, along with his wife Mahalakshmi Subramani, called on President Droupadi Murmu at Rashtrapati Bhavan,” it said. General Subramani, widely known as an expert on Pakistan and China, on Sunday took charge as India’s new CDS.



FADNAVIS DEFENDS BULLDOZER USE AGAINST LAWBREAKERS

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Monday defended the use of bulldozers against illegal construction, asserting the State Government follows due legal process during such action.

Strict action against lawbreakers will continue, he said at an event organised by a news channel here, his remarks coming amid political debate over what is often referred to as “bulldozer justice” against illegal structures generally linked to those accused of crimes.

“I do not speak for any other state. Maharashtra is governed by the rule of law, and action is taken only after following the prescribed procedures. In Maharashtra, if somebody acts beyond the law or does something wrong, bulldozer action is taken against them,” the CM asserted.

The Government has not targeted any individual or community in such cases, and notices are issued before any demolition is carried out, he added.

Monsoon to hit Kerala in next 2-3 days: IMD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As concerns mount over a strengthening El Niño that could influence weather patterns, the southwest monsoon — the lifeline for millions across India — has still not made its official entry into Kerala despite forecasts that had indicated an onset by late May. The southwest monsoon is most likely to miss its date with Kerala on June 1 this year. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Monday said the southwest monsoon is expected to arrive in Kerala in the next two to three days. Typically, the season begins around June 1. This is now the third time forecasters have had to push the date back.

“Conditions are favourable for further advance of southwest monsoon into some more parts of southwest and southeast Arabian Sea, Lakshadweep Islands, some



parts of Kerala and Tamil Nadu during the next two to three days,” the weather department said. The advance can also take place in some more parts of the southwest, west-central, east-central and northeast Bay of Bengal, and the remaining parts of the southeast Bay of Bengal during the period, it is predicted.

The IMD had earlier predicted the onset of monsoon over Kerala on May 26. However, the arrival of the monsoon was delayed, and

the department stated on May 29 that it could happen the following week. That date, however, passed without any onset. The forecast then shifted to May 28, and then back to the usual time of around June 1.

Now, the IMD says the onset will not happen before June 3, and the actual arrival could be later still.

In its revised forecast last week, the department said the season’s rainfall would be below normal. It noted that India is expected to receive

90 per cent of its Long Period Average (LPA) this year.

LPA refers to the rainfall recorded over a particular region for a given interval, such as a month or season, averaged over a long period, typically 30 to 50 years.

The LPA of seasonal rainfall over India as a whole, based on data from 1971 to 2020, is 87 centimetres.

If a monsoon season sees less than 90 per cent of the LPA rainfall, the IMD classifies it as “deficient”. One reason behind the below-normal rainfall this year could be the emergence of El Niño conditions, which lead to less rain during the monsoon in India, the IMD said.

Currently, neutral El Niño-Southern Oscillation conditions are transitioning towards El Niño conditions over the equatorial Pacific region, it said. El Niño conditions are likely to be weak in June and moderate to strong in September, it added.

Census 2027: J&K leads Union Territories in self-enumeration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir has topped the list among all Union Territories and secured the eighth position among states in the self-enumeration phase of Census 2027, a senior Census official said. The official added that more than 6.67 lakh households have voluntarily submitted their details through the official portal so far.

He said that 6,67,517 households in Jammu and Kashmir and 7,009 households in Ladakh completed self-enumeration before the commencement of house listing operations (HLO), which began on Monday.

The official appealed to all residents of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh to extend full cooperation to enumerators and supervisors visiting households during the month-long



census exercise. “J&K has emerged as the leading Union Territory and 8th among States in the country in self-enumeration under the census 2027. Over 6.67 lakh households voluntarily submitted their details through the official Self-Enumeration portal,” Chief Principal Census Officer and Director Census Operations for Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, Amit Sharma told reporters.

Describing the response as highly encouraging, Sharma

said, “Residents across districts actively participated in the exercise, with Pulwama, Jammu and Kulgam recording particularly strong responses”.

He also appreciated the participation of residents from Leh and Kargil districts in Ladakh. Sharma thanked district administrations, principal census officers, field functionaries, media organisations and residents for contributing to the successful completion of the self-enumeration phase.

BWSSB to deploy AI to curb water theft and leakages

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bengaluru

In a major push towards technology-driven water management, the BWSSB is set to explore the use of AI, predictive analytics, and robotic inspection technologies to detect water theft, reduce leakages, and improve operational efficiency across Bengaluru’s water distribution network, officials said on Monday.

As part of the initiative, Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board (BWSSB) has agreed to facilitate a joint pilot study by two emerging startups — SmartTerra and Solinas — aimed at identifying sources of Unaccounted-for Water (UFW) and reducing Non-Revenue Water (NRW) losses in the city, they said.

“The project has been selected under the Titan Design Impact Awards 2.0 — Deep Impact Phase and will be funded entirely through a grant from Titan Company Limited. The initiative is being supported by Villgro as the incubation partner and WELL Labs as the technical partner,” BWSSB said in a statement.

Notably, the year-long study will be implemented at zero cost to BWSSB, with the utility only provid-



ing support for essential civil works such as excavation, pipe repairs, and replacement wherever required, it said.

According to BWSSB, the pilot will leverage a combination of advanced technologies to improve network intelligence and asset management.

SmartTerra will deploy AI-driven predictive analytics to identify vulnerable pipeline segments and assess potential leakage risks before failures occur, it said.

The startup will also use acoustic sensing technology to accurately

pinpoint underground leak locations without extensive excavation, officials said.

Meanwhile, Solinas will undertake robotic inspection of water pipelines, deploying specialised robots inside distribution networks to detect structural defects, blockages, and hidden leakages that are otherwise difficult to identify through conventional methods, they said.

The technologies are expected to help BWSSB continuously monitor water distribution patterns, assess demand, detect losses, improve

billing efficiency, and strengthen revenue collection mechanisms, officials said.

Speaking on the initiative, BWSSB Chairman V Ram Prasath Manohar said the Board is committed to creating opportunities for innovative startups to validate and scale solutions that can address real-world urban water challenges.

“We are opening our infrastructure as a ‘test bed’ for startups developing cutting-edge solutions for urban water management. Data-driven scientific approaches and digital workflows have the potential to significantly transform how cities manage water resources,” he said. Manohar added that priority zones for the pilot study will be identified shortly, following which field surveys and technology deployment will commence.

“Our primary objective is to reduce financial losses caused by water leakages and theft, while also preventing contamination arising from defects in the distribution network. If successful, these technologies could become an important component of Bengaluru’s future water management strategy,” he said.



■ **States Focus** ■



NITIN NABIN CONGRATULATES JEE ADVANCED TOPPER

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Monday congratulated Shubham Kumar, who topped the Joint Entrance Examination (Advanced) 2026, or JEE, and said the feat will serve as an inspiration for lakhs of students across the country, including Bihar.

Nabin also congratulated all the other students who cleared the entrance exam for admissions to engineering programmes, and encouraged those who could not succeed this time, saying, "I am confident that your patience and consistent efforts will bring you great success in the future." Shubham of the IIT Delhi zone, who hails from Gaya in Bihar, secured the top position in the common rank list (CRL) for the highly competitive, national-level exam, scoring 330 out of 360. The JEE-Advanced results were announced on Monday. (PTI)



ASSAM CM HIMANTA MEETS VP RADHAKRISHNAN

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma called on Vice President CP Radhakrishnan at the Uparashtrapati Bhavan in New Delhi on Monday.

This was Sarma's first meeting with the vice president since taking the oath as Assam chief minister for a second consecutive term on May 12. Radhakrishnan took charge as vice president in September 2025.

"Chief Minister of Assam, Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma, called on Vice President CP Radhakrishnan at Uprashtrapati Bhavan today," the Vice President's office posted on social media. Sarma had previously called on the vice president in December 2025 and extended an invitation to him to visit Assam. In March this year, Radhakrishnan undertook a three-day visit to Nagaland, Mizoram and Tripura. (PTI)

India, Australia review defence ties, Indo-Pacific

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Australia on Monday reviewed the whole range of bilateral defence ties and affirmed the importance of enhancing cooperation with regional partners to help maintain a free, open, peaceful, stable and prosperous Indo-Pacific.

These were some of the crucial takeaways during the second edition of India-Australia Defence Ministers' Dialogue co-chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Richard Marles.

The two Ministers welcomed the significant progress in the bilateral relationship and reflected on the enhanced consultation and cooperation since the inaugural edition of the dialogue on October 9, 2025.



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh during a meeting with Australian Deputy Prime Minister and Defence Minister Richard Marles in New Delhi (PTI)

The Ministers advanced their Prime Ministers' long-term vision for collaboration between the two countries to enhance collective strength, contribute to both countries' security, and make an important contribution to regional peace and security. They welcomed the progress towards realising their Prime Minister's commitment to renew and strengthen the joint

Declaration on Defence and Security Cooperation.

The two sides discussed advancements in bilateral maritime security cooperation and efforts to finalise the Joint Maritime Security Collaboration Roadmap. They agreed to progress the collaborative maritime domain awareness activities by maritime patrol aircraft and explore opportunities to enhance undersea

domain awareness. They also encouraged further cooperation between the Indian Coast Guard and Australia's Maritime Border Command.

The Ministers affirmed the importance of enhancing cooperation with regional partners to help maintain a free, open, peaceful, stable and prosperous Indo-Pacific.

They underscored the importance of freedom of navigation and overflight, and their strong support for unimpeded trade in the region and other lawful uses of the sea consistent with international law, particularly the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS).

Both Ministers looked forward to exploring future defence science and technology research cooperation in new technology areas like sensor technologies.

BJP accuses Kapil Sibal of 'hating India'

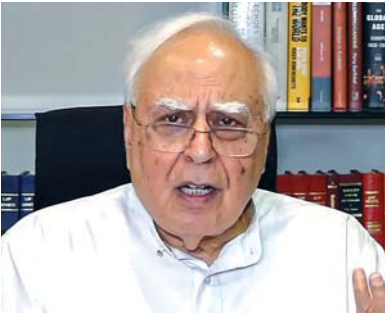
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday hit out at Rajya Sabha MP and senior advocate Kapil Sibal over his remarks criticising the ruling party, accusing him of "hating India" and alleging that he remained silent on incidents of post-poll violence in West Bengal in 2021.

The attack came in response to Sibal's remarks on Sunday that he was ashamed that he was living in a country where the party in power would use any means to destroy the foundations of democracy, while referring to the attack on TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee.

In a video statement, BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla said the senior advocate earned "crores of rupees" by practising in the country's Supreme Court and yet claimed to be ashamed of living in India.

"Kapil Sibal says that he is ashamed to live in India. The question is, when



post-poll violence happened in 2021, and more than 300 BJP workers and Congress workers were allegedly killed, Kapil Sibal never opened his mouth. The same Kapil Sibal kept quiet even during cases such as RG Kar and Sandeshkhali," he said.

Poonawalla said political differences with the Government are acceptable, but questioned a "tendency" among some Opposition leaders to attack the

country because of their opposition to the BJP.

"Opposing the BJP is one thing, but why oppose India? You can have political differences, but why hate India?" Poonawalla said.

He also referred to Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's past remarks and alleged that some Opposition leaders routinely questioned India's democratic institutions, judiciary and security forces.

"Today, just because you have a problem with the BJP, you end up hating India. Rahul Gandhi says that he will fight the Indian State. He says democracy is over and that the US and the UK need to intervene. Kapil Sibal says he is ashamed to live in India. Somebody else questions the valour of our forces during Operation Sindoor. Somebody questions the democratic institutions of this country. Somebody challenges the judiciary," he said.

Would not tolerate Andhra leaders' interference: Kavitha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Alleging that political leaders of neighbouring Andhra Pradesh are trying to interfere in Telangana affairs, TRS president K Kavitha on Monday said that she would not tolerate any such interference in governance and in the cultural sphere.

Speaking at an event in Hyderabad, the Telangana Rakshana Sena (TRS) founder said she would not hesitate to break the statues of Andhra personalities now installed in Hyderabad against the wishes of Telangana people when her party comes to power.

She also demanded that Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy announce on Tuesday,

on the occasion of Telangana Formation Day, regarding the implementation of pre-poll promises made by the ruling Congress to those who fought for Telangana statehood.

She said political leaders of Andhra Pradesh should not belittle Telangana people and should not try to show "cultural dominance" on Telangana, she said.

"The damage caused (to Telangana) because their agent is the chief minister here. They are installing different types of statues. I had said earlier. I am not as good as leaders in the past. We will definitely come to power. If you continue like this, we will break all statues and send them by parcel to Andhra. I don't have so much patience,



such broad-mindedness," she said. She was speaking in an apparent reference to TDP founder NT Rama Rao's statue, which was unveiled by CM Revanth Reddy recently in Hyderabad.

Kavitha said investors from Andhra Pradesh are welcome in Telangana.

"Our problem is not with them (investors). Our problem is with Andhra political leaders if they say that they will interfere in secretariat affairs," she said.

She also said her party would take care of Andhra-origin people settled in Hyderabad.

Naidu vows poverty-free society, boosts welfare

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chamavaram

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Monday said here that he envisions a poverty-free society and remains committed to addressing the needs of the poor.

Addressing a public meeting in Chamavaram village, the CM said the TDP-led NDA Government has been working for the welfare of the poor since day one, and that the increase in welfare pensions reflects this commitment.

"My dream is to see a poverty-free society. I always think about fulfilling the basic needs of the poor," said Naidu, adding that pensions under various categories have been



increased to as much as ₹15,000 per month.

According to the CM, the State Government is spending ₹32,000 crore annually on welfare pensions alone, unlike any other State in the country.

Naidu said the Government has initiated measures to deliver welfare, development, and good governance, while

also creating employment opportunities.

He said the Government is planning to ensure that the youth of the State need not relocate elsewhere for jobs.

He added that investments worth ₹23 lakh crore were attracted over the past 23 months, which are expected to generate employment for

23 lakh people.

Observing that the Visakhapatnam Steel Plant (VSP) has been revived with the support of the Centre, he said the long-pending dream of establishing the South Coast Railway Zone, headquartered in the port city, has also been realised.

Speaking about public health, the CM said the Government is working towards introducing a universal health policy to prevent people from falling into a debt trap while availing expensive medical treatment.

He said an 'AI doctor' facility will be introduced to help people with doctor appointments, medicines, and resolving various health-related queries.

Jal Shakti Ministry and ISRO sign MoU for water management

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Jal Shakti and space agency Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) on Monday signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) to strengthen the use of satellite technology and space-based applications for water resource management in the country.

The agreement was signed during a national workshop on research and development (R&D) in the water sector organised by the Ministry of Jal Shakti at the Dr Ambedkar International Centre in New Delhi.

Under the MoU, the Department of Water Resources and the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) will jointly work in 24 key research areas, including reservoir monitoring, water-spread assessment, river-flow analysis, satellite-based water quality assessment and studies on macroplastic distribution in water bodies.

Addressing the workshop, Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil said water security is critical for achieving the goal of "Viksit Bharat" by 2047, and that water-related challenges must be addressed through



Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil

technology, innovation, traditional knowledge and public participation.

"Water security is a critical foundation for achieving the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047. Solutions to water-related challenges must be driven by technology, innovation, traditional knowledge and people's participation," Patil said.

The minister said the ministry had supported several research studies in the past decade, including 113 directly sponsored projects, which helped develop practical solutions in the water sector.

Patil also launched the third phase of the Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari (JSJB) campaign and announced a target of creating two crore water conservation structures

between June 2026 and May 2027. He said the previous phase had crossed 1.5 crore structures.

The workshop also saw the launch of the mission for advancement in high-impact areas (MAHA)-Water programme, a joint initiative of the Ministry of Jal Shakti and the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF), and an open call for startups and MSMEs under the Bharat Water Innovation Network (Bharat WIN) platform.

ISRO chairman and Department of Space secretary V Narayanan said the agreement will deepen collaboration between the two organisations and strengthen the use of satellite-based applications for water management.

Vice Admiral Vineet McCarty takes charge of Andaman and Nicobar Command

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Vice Admiral Vineet McCarty assumed charge as the 20th Commander-in-Chief, Andaman & Nicobar Command (ANC) at Sri Vijaya Puram on Monday, the defence ministry said.

Commissioned into the Indian Navy on July 1, 1989, the Flag Officer is a specialist in Gunnery and Missiles. An alumnus of the Defence Services Staff College, Wellington, and the National Defence College, New Delhi, he brings over 36 years of distinguished service across operational, staff, training and tri-service domains.

Vice Admiral McCarty's sea tenures include serving as part of the commissioning crew of INS Delhi and completing all specialist appointments onboard the frontline destroyer. He has commanded INS Ajay, INS Khanjar and INS Shivalik.

His key staff and training roles include Training Commander at the Indian Naval Academy, Command Plans Officer at Headquarters Eastern Naval Command, and Commodore Naval Plans at Naval Headquarters.



On promotion to Flag Rank in 2020, he served as Assistant Chief of Naval Staff (Staff Requirements), Controller of Personnel Services, and commanded the Western Fleet as Flag Officer Commanding Western Fleet (FOCWF) in 2023. He was the tenth Commandant of the Indian Naval Academy in 2024.

Before his current appointment, the officer held consecutive tri-service appointments at Headquarters Integrated Defence Staff (HQ IDS) as Deputy Chief of Integrated Defence Staff (Policy, Plans and Force Development) and Deputy Chief of

Integrated Defence Staff (Doctrine, Organisation and Training) during 2025-26.

His overseas assignments include serving as Directing Staff at the Naval and Maritime Academy, Sri Lanka, and as Defence Advisor to Singapore and the Philippines concurrently from 2011 to 2015.

On assuming charge as Commander-in-Chief, Andaman & Nicobar Command, Vice Admiral McCarty emphasised the strategic significance of the Command in safeguarding India's maritime interests and ensuring stability and security in the Indian Ocean Region.

Mizoram: Unions oppose mandatory 'Mizotaxi' app

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Aizawl

Days after the Mizoram Government announced the launch of a new mobile application for public transport services to protect commuters from overcharging, three associations on Monday opposed the move to make it mandatory for passenger transport operators.

The associations also urged their members not to register on the platform until the issue is reviewed.

The Mizoram Government had recently announced the launch of 'MizoTaxi', a mobile application for public transport services designed to ensure passengers pay Government-approved fares.

In a joint statement issued on Monday, the Mizoram Taxi Association (MTA), Aizawl Two Wheeler Taxi Association (ATTA), and Aizawl District Auto-Rickshaw Owners Association (ADAROA) said they were dissatisfied with the Government's directive requiring passenger transport vehicles to operate through the online platform.

The associations, during a meeting on Saturday, resolved to appeal to the authorities concerned to



withdraw the decision at the earliest, the statement said.

They also issued an advisory to their members, urging them to refrain from downloading or registering on the application until further notice.

According to an official release issued by the Secretary of the State Transport Authority on May 29, the 'MizoTaxi' app will initially be rolled out in Aizawl city and is set to become operational from July 1.

It is designed to help people using taxis, two-wheeler taxis, and auto-rickshaws verify and pay the correct fares approved by the Government.

All four-wheeler taxis, two-wheeler taxis, and auto-rickshaws operating within the State Capital have been asked to complete registration on the 'MizoTaxi' platform in June.

Maharashtra: e-KYC renders 80 lakh women beneficiaries ineligible

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Around 80 lakh women have become ineligible to receive benefits under the Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana post an e-KYC process, leading the Opposition to allege the Maharashtra Government was weeding out recipients due to a "severe financial crisis".

However, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis rejected allegations that the Government had removed lakhs of women from the cash transfer scheme, asserting only ineligible beneficiaries were weeded out through a verification process.

A senior official informed that the beneficiary count has dropped from 2.4 crore to nearly 1.7 crore after the e-KYC (Know Your Customer) deadline of April 30, but the disqualifications were also linked to non-compliance with the eligibility criteria of the scheme launched two years ago.

The Government had provided an eight-month window for beneficiaries to complete their e-KYC to continue getting the monthly stipend of ₹1,500 under the scheme targeted at poorer women, he said.

"Around 50 to 55 lakh women failed to complete the process entirely, while



two to three lakh rectified errors during this period. Additionally, nearly 12 lakh women were found to be income-tax payers exceeding the annual income cap of ₹2.5 lakh (under the scheme), and over 4.5 lakh had crossed the upper age limit of 65 years," the official said.

Around five lakh women were already receiving benefits under the Namo Shetkari scheme for farmers, he added.

Addressing complaints that women who completed e-KYC missed monthly instalments, the official noted, "The final figure of actual beneficiaries will be clear in a week, and the complaints are being cross-verified."

He denied that 80 lakh

women were dropped from the scheme solely on the grounds of non-completion of e-KYC.

Fadnavis said the Government had not excluded any eligible woman from the flagship welfare scheme and insisted the verification exercise was aimed at ensuring benefits reached only deserving beneficiaries.

"We have not excluded anyone. There were several criteria for eligibility. We initiated the KYC process and identified beneficiaries who were either ineligible or had discrepancies in their records," the CM said at an event organised by a regional news channel in Mumbai.

According to the chief min-

ister, the verification exercise revealed that around 14,000 men, five lakh Government employees, 10 lakh income-tax payers and five lakh vehicle owners had been receiving benefits despite not meeting the eligibility conditions.

Fadnavis noted that beneficiaries who failed to complete the mandatory KYC process and those found ineligible were blocked from receiving payments under the scheme.

The CM said errors were also detected in the KYC details of about 25 lakh women beneficiaries, and these records were subsequently corrected.

"The Government is ready to undertake the KYC process again. However, those who are ineligible will not receive any money under the scheme," he emphasised.

Describing the scheme as the largest welfare programme of its kind implemented by any State, Fadnavis said the Government remained committed to extending benefits to all eligible women while ensuring transparency and preventing misuse of public funds.

Opposition NCP (SP) leader Jayant Patil, however, claimed that the dropping of beneficiaries from the scheme reflects a "severe financial crisis" faced by the State.

TN CM Vijay rejects horse-trading charge, slams DMK and AIADMK

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Tiruchirappalli (Tamil Nadu)

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Monday rejected the horse-trading charge levelled against him by the Opposition parties, and accused the main rivals DMK and AIADMK of surreptitiously "attempting to form the Government to loot".

Addressing his maiden rally after assuming charge as chief minister on May 10, Vijay slammed the DMK for persistently criticising him and his TVK and alleged that the DMK's "family politics" was the reason for the Dravidian major's defeat in the April 23 Assembly election.

"The people have made me the 'first sewak', not chief minister," he said and added that the more the DMK criticised him, the more advantageous it would turn out for the TVK. After the election results were declared on May 4, the two Dravidian parties engaged in a bargain, and they secretly tried to form the Government so as to loot.

"It was because if the TVK formed the Government, their 'business'—loot and corruption—would be lost," he alleged



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay addressing a public rally in Tiruchirappalli, Tamil Nadu

and slammed the DMK as an "evil force" and the AIADMK as a "spent force."

Launching a sharp attack on the DMK for criticising his newly formed TVK Government, Vijay said those who initially promised to remain silent for six months to let his new Government settle down, could not even wait for six days before aggressively criticising his Government.

"As I said earlier, the contest is only between the TVK and DMK, and others don't matter," the TVK president said, addressing the meeting at St Joseph's College here to thank the voters for ensuring a victory for his party.

Though people refer to him as MLA of Perambur, as far as he was concerned, the people of the Tiruchirappalli constituen-

cy were very close to his heart. He said even the late chief minister MG Ramachandran did not secure so much vote share as the TVK did in the first election.

"You have extended such tremendous support to the TVK. The votes that were not cast in 1977 were cast in 2026. I am not comparing myself with MGR," he said.

He continued saying, "MGR is MGR, and I am your Vijay who has come to work on the path shown by MGR, Anna and Periyar, that's all," the chief minister said.

"The only thing is, if you had supported a little bit more, it would have turned out a bit better. But it's okay, in all the elections to come in the future, your full support will be there," Vijay said.

TIFFANY TRUMP ARRIVES IN JAMNAGAR TO VISIT VANTARA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jamnagar

Tiffany Trump, daughter of US President Donald Trump, arrived in Gujarat's Jamnagar on Monday as part of a private visit to India. Accompanied by her husband, Michael Boulos and a small group of associates, she is expected to visit Vantara, the wildlife rescue and rehabilitation initiative



supported by the Ambani family.

A chartered aircraft carrying the visitors landed at Jamnagar Airport around midday, where security arrangements were put in place for their arrival. The delegation proceeded directly to Vantara under tight security.

Before reaching Gujarat, Tiffany Trump reportedly visited several prominent Indian landmarks, including Akshardham Temple in New Delhi, the Taj Mahal in Agra, and Jaisalmer Fort in Rajasthan.

CBI recreates crime scene at Twisha Sharma's marital home

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI on Monday did a crime scene recreation using dummies in connection with the death of former model-actor Twisha Sharma, who allegedly hung herself at her marital home on May 12, officials said.

The agency, along with forensic and crime scene experts, took Sharma's husband Samarth Singh and mother-in-law Giribala Singh, both in CBI custody, to give a detailed account of happenings on the night of May 12 when the incident took place, they said. The CBI asked them to describe the events after she allegedly hanged herself on the terrace of the home, they said.

A dummy weighing similar to the deceased was used to mimic the crime scene in the presence of both Samarth and his mother, Giribala Singh, who were asked to enact and explain events after the inci-



dent, they said. The agency also attempted to develop a minute-by-minute timeline to understand the death of Sharma, who allegedly hanged herself at the terrace of her marital home in Katara Hills, Bhopal, they said.

The FIR alleged that Twisha's husband, Samarth, brought her to the AIIMS, Bhopal, after she, her husband claimed, had hanged herself at home at 10.20 pm.

Will clarify stand on new party in 2 days: Annamalai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Amid speculations that he was sulking in the BJP and that he may float a new political party, the saffron party leader from Tamil Nadu, K Annamalai, on Monday said he would clarify his stand in two days.

Asked about speculations that he may launch a new political party, Annamalai, before leaving for Delhi, told reporters at the airport that he would provide answers and make his stand clear in two days.

"Please wait. We will sit down and talk in two days," he told reporters when pressed about the buzz that he is heading to the national Capital to meet party chief Nitin Nabin, as he planned to quit the party.

The former State president's opposition to the recent CBSE's announcement on implementing the three-language policy for Class 9 students from



the current academic year, and his demand to roll back the notification, fuelled speculation that he was opposing the Centre as he was getting geared up to launch his own party.

The former IPS official who played

a crucial role in roping in TTV Dhinakaran and former Chief Minister O Panneerselvam for the 2021 Assembly election has been maintaining a low profile after the party high command replaced him with Nainar

Nagenthiran and revived the electoral pact with the AIADMK ahead of the 2026 Assembly election. Though the party members from the Coimbatore region expected him to contest in the 2026 Assembly election, he later clarified that he opted out of the race.

However, post poll after the NDA's dream of making the Lotus bloom in large numbers and form the first NDA Government in the State was shattered by Vijay-led Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, there were rumblings within the saffron party over the State leadership. The BJP had managed to win only one seat in the recently held election.

A source in the BJP said that Annamalai was unlikely to quit the party as he may be given a bigger role to play. But some of his supporters in Coimbatore favoured the former state president to float a new party as an alternative to the TVK.

Gujarati man faces US deportation for visa fraud

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

A Gujarat-born businessman residing in the United States is facing possible deportation after pleading guilty in connection with a large-scale immigration fraud and money-laundering case.

Federal court documents indicate that Chandrakant "Lala" Patel admitted involvement in a conspiracy linked to the misuse of the US U-visa programme, which is intended to assist victims of serious crimes who cooperate with law-enforcement agencies.

Prosecutors allege that the scheme involved the creation of fraudulent claims and supporting documentation to help individuals obtain immigration benefits.

As part of a plea agree-



ment, Patel has reportedly agreed to forfeit multiple assets, including bank accounts, vehicles, jewellery and real estate holdings.

The case forms part of a broader federal investigation into alleged immigration-related fraud activities. Sentencing will be determined by the court following completion of the pre-sentence review process.

Gujarat Police bust ₹2,289 cr cyber fraud

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

Gujarat Police has reported major progress in its fight against cybercrime after a state-wide operation targeting suspected mule bank accounts revealed cyber fraud transactions worth approximately ₹2,289 crore.

The operation, led by the Cyber Centre of Excellence (CCOE), focused on identifying bank accounts allegedly used by cybercriminals to receive, transfer and conceal funds obtained through online fraud. Law enforcement agencies across the state coordinated efforts to track and investigate such accounts.

Officials said the initiative involved extensive data analysis and cooper-



ation with national cyber-crime platforms, banking institutions and law enforcement networks.

The operation aimed to strengthen action against financial channels frequently exploited in digital fraud cases.

Authorities also high-

lighted upcoming technological measures, including AI-based risk assessment systems designed to identify suspicious transactions and accounts more effectively.

These initiatives are expected to enhance preventive action against cyber-enabled financial crimes.

Goa CM, Bhupender Yadav discuss green initiatives

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant on Monday met Union Minister for Environment, Forest and Climate Change Bhupender Yadav in New Delhi to discuss environmental initiatives in the coastal State.

The Chief Minister's Office (CMO) released a

photograph of the meeting, with a brief statement that Sawant held discussions with the Union minister on various aspects of sustainable development and green growth in Goa.

While the CMO did not share further details of the meeting, sources said that the chief minister is on a two-day visit to the national Capital, his second in one week.



ECI reviews progress of SIR in Sikkim

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gangtok

The Election Commission on Monday reviewed the progress of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Sikkim, a statement said.

ECI Director Shubhra Saxena assessed the status of Enumeration Form distribution, elector verification and other activities during a meeting held at the Office of the Chief Electoral Officer in Gangtok.

Emphasising the importance of maintaining accurate and inclusive electoral rolls, she directed officials to ensure that all eligible voters are covered during the revision exercise.

Saxena, who is on a visit to the state till June 4, stressed that Booth Level Officers



(BLOs) must actively assist electors in filling up Enumeration Forms and uploading the required information through the ECINET portal.

The review meeting also discussed the verification and mapping of electors whose records may not be readily traceable in earlier electoral rolls.

Officials were advised to adopt appropriate verification procedures and make

effective use of available records to ensure accurate identification and enrolment of eligible electors, the statement said.

Saxena underscored the need for meticulous field-level verification and strict adherence to timelines prescribed by the ECI for the successful completion of the SIR.

The meeting was attended by CEO Raj Kumar Yadav, District Election Officers and Booth Level Officers.

HISAR SPINNING MILLS LIMITED
9TH K.M. STONE, HISAR BHIWANI ROAD,
V.P.O. DABRA, HISAR - 125005
CIN-L17112HR1992PLC031621, PAN-AAACH3754M
Tel - 01662-297005, Email- hsm12000@rediffmail.com
Website : www.hisarspinningmills.com



STATEMENT OF FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31ST MARCH, 2026
The audited Financial Results of Hisar Spinning Mills Limited ("the Company") along with the Audit Report of the Statutory Auditors of the Company for the quarter and year ended 31st March, 2026 have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by Board of Directors of the Company at their Meeting held on 29th May, 2026, in terms of Regulation 33 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.
The aforementioned financial results along with the Audit Report of the Statutory Auditors thereon are available on the website of BSE Limited (BSE) (www.bseindia.com) and on the Company's website at <https://www.hisarspinningmills.com/images/pdf/Hsml%20Results%2031.03.2026.pdf>.
The same can also be accessed by scanning the QR Code provided above:
By Order of the Board of Directors for Hisar Spinning Mills Limited
Sd/-
(Anurag Gupta)
Managing Director
DIN: 00192888
Date: 29.05.2026
Place: Chandigarh



Editor's
TAKE

India's strategic gamble with Myanmar's Junta

As Myanmar's President Min Aung Hlaing visits India, strategic imperatives appear to be outweighing democratic principles

Myanmar's President Min Aung Hlaing is in India on his five-day maiden visit. The controversy and protests started even as he landed in Bodh Gaya on Saturday. The optics were meticulously choreographed, but the baggage the President carries is simply too heavy to be whitewashed. Here was a man who led a coup against a democratically elected government in 2021, receiving ceremonial honours from the world's largest democracy. In February 2021, military chief Min Aung Hlaing overthrew Myanmar's democratically elected government, arresting Aung San Suu Kyi on flimsy charges. But this time, the resistance was sizeable. The junta has lost control of over half the country's territory. Desperate to project legitimacy, the military has staged heavily restricted, staggered elections – widely dismissed as a sham - with the NLD dissolved and major rebel groups boycotting the process entirely, leaving Myanmar's political crisis far from resolution.

Yet to dismiss India's decision to host him as a moral contradiction would be simplistic. It is a bid to balance the geopolitics of the region and engage with a regime that rules an important neighbour. India shares 1,643 kilometres of border with Myanmar. Across that frontier lie insurgent groups, drug-trafficking networks, and the shadow of Chinese influence. No Indian government, regardless of its ideological persuasion, can afford to look away from Naypyidaw simply because its leader came to power through a coup. Three imperatives have consistently driven India's Myanmar calculus. First, instability in Myanmar spills directly into India's North-East. Managing that volatility requires engagement, not isolation. Second, India's Act East policy – its strategic pivot towards South-East Asia - depends critically on Myanmar as its land bridge. The Kaladan Multi-Modal Corridor, the India-Myanmar-Thailand Highway, and the Sittwe Port are not abstract diplomatic assets; they are concrete infrastructure projects that India has spent years and considerable resources building. Third, and perhaps most urgently, China looms large. Beijing has embedded itself deeply in Myanmar's economy. For India, allowing the junta to drift entirely into China's orbit is simply not an option.

New Delhi engaged with the junta through the 1990s. History, it seems, keeps repeating itself, but it also carries warnings. By legitimising Min Aung Hlaing, India risks being seen as an enabler of a regime that has prosecuted a brutal civil conflict and conducted deeply contested elections.

The National Unity Government and exiled communities in Delhi are already protesting New Delhi's decision to host the President. The deeper question is whether India's engagement actually moves Myanmar towards a genuine democratic transition – or whether it merely allows the junta to garner international respectability while continuing business as usual at home. New Delhi would argue that engagement beats isolation. But engagement without pressure on the junta to restore democracy will reflect poorly on India's standing. How New Delhi articulates its position will go a long way towards balancing its moral position and regional compulsions.

BHASKAR JYOTI
MAHANTA

The sea does not forgive strategic ambivalence. Nations that have ceded control of maritime chokepoints, neglected their shipbuilding base, or outsourced the transshipment of their own cargo to foreign intermediaries have, without exception, paid a steep geopolitical price. India, for much of its post-Independence history, was content to watch from the shoreline. That posture is now being dismantled, deliberately, systematically, and with a clarity of national purpose that commands attention.

The architectural framework for this transformation rests on two interlocking blueprints. Maritime India Vision 2030 provides the operational scaffolding, with over 150 initiatives targeting vessel turnaround times, coastal shipping expansion, and a doubling of major port capacity to 1,630 Million Tonnes Per Annum (MTPA). The Amrit Kaal Vision 2047 casts a longer shadow: more than 300 benchmarks pointing towards smart ports, dedicated shipbuilding clusters, and carbon neutrality across India's major transit hubs. Together, these are not wish lists; they are the coordinates of a nation that has chosen to compete at the apex of global maritime commerce.

Physical infrastructure, however, is only as durable as the law that governs it. Three landmark pieces of legislation enacted in 2025 have restructured the regulatory foundation from the ground up. The Merchant Shipping Act broadened vessel definitions, dismantled archaic ownership restrictions inherited from the colonial era, and created competitive financing pathways to incentivise international tonnage to fly the Indian flag.

The Indian Ports Act harmonised domestic port operations with international green safety standards, including rigorous ballast-water management protocols in line with the IMO's Ballast Water Management Convention - a compliance posture that shields Indian ports from regulatory penalties and signals premium reliability to global shipping lines. The Coastal Shipping Act, by decentralising customs barriers for domestic cabotage, has already triggered a 118 per cent surge in coastal shipping volumes, freeing deep-water berths for high-value international cargo.

Perhaps no single indicator better captures the seriousness of India's international commitment than its implementation of the Hong Kong International Convention for the Safe and Environmentally Sound Recycling of Ships, 2009. For years, the vessel-recycling industry at Alang, the world's largest ship-breaking yard, attracted both economic interest and humanitarian criticism. India's ratification and progressive imple-



INDIA'S 7,500-KILOMETRE COASTLINE HAS ALWAYS BEEN A GEOGRAPHIC FACT. IT IS NOW BECOMING A STRATEGIC INSTRUMENT. POLICYMAKERS WHO FAIL TO GRASP THE FULL WEIGHT OF THAT SHIFT WILL FIND THEMSELVES OPERATING WITH AN OUTDATED MAP.

The author is a former DGP of Assam and is presently engaged in think-tank activities

- dailypioneer
- @thedailypioneer
- The Pioneer

When justice fails, revenge takes centre stage



SHANKAR SAHAY

2ND OPINION

Sidney Sheldon famously observed that, to the ancient Greeks, the concept of justice (*dikaiosisini*) was often synonymous with vengeance (*ekdikisis*). *Vadh-2* and *System*, two films released this week on OTT, are based on this very belief. The cornerstone of both films is: "If the system can't deliver justice, then it's acceptable to take the law into your own hands and seek revenge."

As expected, while *Dhurandhar* and *Dhurandhar-2: The Revenge*, which dish out nationalism in the garb of chauvinism, keep the moolah flowing into the multiplexes, these two films, which portray the pain of ordinary people and their fight back, find shelter in the comfort of home on OTT platforms.

After all, who cares so much about the common man



that they would visit a theatre to watch a film?

While both films depict protagonists facing immense misery at the hands of the high and mighty and then plotting actions that result in the downfall of culprits who got away scot-free under the law, the story of *Vadh-2* spans decades, whereas in *System*, justice comes more swiftly.

Also, while in *Vadh-2* the wrongly framed character accidentally gets an opportunity to settle scores, the victims in *System* plan their moves meticulously. While *Vadh-2* begins at the crime scene and then moves to prison, *System* opens in prison and then takes viewers back to the crime. Both films slowly unravel the losses

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

suffered by the have-nots, their hardships, and finally their retaliation.

The films explicitly depict how the affluent use not only the judiciary and police but the entire system to shift the blame onto the downtrodden and escape accountability. Apart from sterling performances by the casts of both films, one remarkable feature of *Vadh-2* is seeing Luv Ranjan produce a film that is neither a love story nor one that blames girls while supporting boys. Similarly, it is a pleasure to see Jyotika and Sonakshi after a long time in *System*.

So, if you are sick and tired of the bravado of *Dhurandhar*, or are waiting for *Dhurandhar-2* to arrive on OTT, these two films are worth watching.

Both *Vadh-2* and *System* tap into a growing public frustration with institutions that often appear inaccessible to ordinary citizens. Though rooted in the unsettling idea of vigilante justice, the films compellingly portray the anguish of the powerless and their quest for accountability.

In an era dominated by larger-than-life nationalist spectacles, these OTT releases offer a more grounded reflection on inequality, injustice, and the moral dilemmas that arise when the system itself seems to fail.

The writer is an educator author, and corporate coach

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Data breach demands accountability

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) broke its silence on the ongoing controversy surrounding On-Screen Marking (OSM) on Sunday. However, what stands out most in this entire episode is not only the alleged security vulnerability of the portal, but also the alarming manner in which students' sensitive information was left exposed, highlighting a significant lapse in data security.

While the CBSE has done well to acknowledge the issue and deploy cybersecurity experts, its response appears to be reactive rather than responsible, as action was taken only after the matter was flagged publicly.

The mix-up reported by a Class 12 student during re-evaluation adds another layer of concern. These are not minor glitches. For students, who trust the system with their academic future, such lapses by the institution are deeply unsettling.

The Board's assurance must be followed by greater transparency; who was affected, what data was accessed, and what structural changes are being made to prevent a recurrence.

The youth of our nation deserve more than reassurances on social media. Accountability, not silence, is what the system owes these students.

A. MYLSAMI | COIMBATORE

Adieu Suman Kalyanpur

The passing of veteran playback singer and Padma Bhushan awardee Suman Kalyanpur marks the end of a cherished chapter in Indian music. She belonged to a generation of artists whose voices helped define the golden age of Bollywood and left an indelible imprint on the cultural memory of the nation. Her departure is not merely the loss of a singer but the fading of one of the last living links to an extraordinary musical era.

Suman Kalyanpur possessed a voice of remarkable elegance and emotional depth. Classics such as "Na Tum Hamen Jano," "Dil Ek Mandir Hai," "Aaj Kal Tere Mere Pyar Ke Charche," and "Tumne Pukara Aur Hum Chale Aaye" continue to evoke nostalgia among listeners. Her memorable duets with Mohammed Rafi remain benchmarks of musical harmony and artistic excellence.

Despite sharing an era with some of the greatest names in Indian playback singing, she carved out her own distinct identity through dedication and humility. Her journey serves as an enduring inspiration to aspiring musicians who seek success through talent and perseverance rather than publicity. Though Suman Kalyanpur is no longer with us, her timeless melodies will continue to echo through generations, ensuring that her legacy remains immortal.

RUKMA SHARMA | PUNJAB

AI: India's women at the forefront

The latest Stanford AI Index 2026 report offers encouraging evidence of India's growing influence in the field of artificial intelligence. Particularly noteworthy is the finding that Indian women have achieved an AI-skill penetration score of 1.9, surpassing their counterparts in countries such as the United States and the United Kingdom.

For decades, advanced technologies were largely associated with a handful of developed nations. Today, Indian women are increasingly participating in and shaping one of the most transformative technological revolutions of our time. Their growing engagement with artificial intelligence demonstrates not only access to learning opportunities but also determination to compete and excel on a global stage. However, the significance of this achievement extends beyond statistics. Artificial intelligence is rapidly becoming a foundational skill for the twenty-first century, influencing industries, governance, healthcare, education, and research. The challenge now is to convert technical proficiency into innovation, entrepreneurship, and leadership. Skill development must evolve into the creation of new products, companies, and groundbreaking discoveries. If current trends continue, India's women could play a defining role in shaping the future of AI.

VIJAY SINGH ADHIKARI | UTTARAKHAND

PIC TALK



Devotees carry sacred Ganga water in vessels for Lord Shiva's jalabishek ritual during the Jyeshtha Somwar, in Prayagraj.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



www.dailypioneer.com

- facebook.com/dailypioneer
- @TheDailyPioneer
- instagram.com/dailypioneer
- linkedin.com/in/The Pioneer

RCB's IPL TRIUMPH OFFERS VALUABLE LESSONS BEYOND THE CRICKET FIELD

Royal Challengers Bengaluru's recent IPL triumph offers valuable lessons that extend far beyond the cricket field. What makes their success remarkable is not the dominance of a single superstar or a sweep of individual awards. Instead, the team's victory was built on collective effort, with different players stepping forward at crucial moments throughout the tournament. It demonstrated that sustained success often emerges from teamwork rather than individual brilliance. The achievement also highlights the importance of trust and long-term commitment. Virat Kohli's enduring association with the franchise has been widely praised as an example of loyalty and perseverance. His journey reflects the reality that meaningful success often requires patience, resilience, and faith in a shared vision. Equally significant

was the management's willingness to stand by players during difficult phases. In modern professional environments, individuals are often judged solely by short-term results. RCB's approach showed the value of supporting people through setbacks rather than discarding them at the first sign of failure. Such confidence can inspire individuals to rediscover their potential and contribute meaningfully when it matters most. The team's success carries an important message for organisations, educational institutions, and workplaces alike. Excellence is achieved when talent is nurtured, trust is maintained, and every individual feels empowered to contribute. RCB's victory a compelling lesson in leadership, teamwork, and organisational culture.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

CBSE's OSM Crisis: Building a trusted digital evaluation system

Drawing on the transparency framework adopted in MCQ-based examinations, there is an urgent need for National Digital Evaluation Model (NDEM) to resolve the OSM crisis and build a trusted digital evaluation system for Gen-N



Teaching-Learning-Evaluation (TLE) is the core of any education system, with evaluation as the most consequential component because it directly affects students' academic progress and future opportunities. After years of effort, preparation, and investment, students have a legitimate right to know how their answer scripts were assessed-how marks were awarded, how step-marking was applied, which responses were left unchecked, and where marks were deducted despite substantial conceptual correctness. Transparency in evaluation is therefore essential for academic fairness and trust. Over the years, concerns have repeatedly surfaced about hurried evaluation, unchecked responses, inconsistent marking, examiner subjectivity, and unexplained variations in awarding marks, highlighting the need for more transparent, verifiable evaluation systems.

Responding to long-standing demands for greater transparency, CBSE introduced the On-Screen Marking (OSM) system for the Class XII Board Examination, replacing conventional pen-and-paper (PnP) evaluation with digital assessment. Physical answer books are scanned and evaluated digitally through a controlled software platform. While this marked a major shift towards transparency and standardisation, the rollout was soon overshadowed by technological glitches, evaluation anomalies, and concerns about the credibility and verifiability of the process.

Broadly, written examinations are of two types: Multiple Choice Question (MCQ)-based (objective) and descriptive (subjective). In both cases, evaluation systems are increasingly expected to leverage digital technologies to improve transparency, standardisation, accountability, and verifiability.

In MCQ-based examinations, evaluation is objective and straightforward because responses are matched against predefined answer keys. Such examinations commonly use Optical Mark Recognition (OMR) sheets, copies of which are often made available to candidates. After provisional answer keys are released, stakeholders may submit objections before final answer keys are frozen. Candidates can then independently estimate and verify their scores against declared results. Since the process is binary and machine-verifiable, it involves minimal subjectivity and limited scope for disputes.

This transparency framework-comprising disclosure of OMR sheets, publication of provisional answer keys, stakeholder feedback, and release of final answer keys-was pioneered and advocated by the author through sustained efforts during the early 2010s. It has since been adopted by most major admission and recruitment examinations in the country, such as IIT, CBSE, NTA, and others. More recently, UPSC adopted the same SOPs for the Civil Services (Preliminary) Examination, 2026.

Beyond transparency, the digital MCQ-OMR ecosystem has also provided valuable audit trails for investigative and judicial scrutiny, including in major admission and recruitment controversies such as the West Bengal teacher recruitment case.

Descriptive examinations operate in a fundamentally different environment. Answers are analytical, interpretative, or procedural, with marks awarded for intermediate steps, reasoning, methodology, diagrams, and presentation rather than a simple right-or-wrong outcome. Consequently, even under a common marking scheme, different evaluators may legitimately award somewhat different marks to the same answer.

This inherent subjectivity necessitates mechanisms for re-checking and re-evaluation. Re-checking verifies assessment and totalling accuracy, while re-evaluation involves a fresh assessment when significant discrepancies are suspected. However, in examinations involving millions of answer scripts, these processes are time-consuming and resource-intensive, and are typically invoked only when serious anomalies are suspected.

Encouraged by the success of digital evaluation in MCQ-based examinations, CBSE reportedly experimented with On-Screen Marking (OSM) on a limited scale



from 2013-14 onwards. The nationwide rollout in 2026, however, represented one of India's largest digital evaluation exercises, involving about 17 lakh Class XII students and nearly 98 lakh answer scripts. Such an undertaking required seamless integration of scanning infrastructure, secure storage, high-capacity servers, evaluation software, trained examiners, moderation systems, and student-access platforms. Given the scale and complexity of the exercise, the rollout appears to have proceeded without adequate large-scale dry runs, stress testing, and stakeholder preparedness, exposing significant implementation challenges.

However, the rollout was soon marred by reports of portal glitches, payment gateway failures, server congestion, and difficulties in accessing scanned answer scripts. Concerns deepened further over blurred scans, missing pages, unchecked responses, inconsistent marking, and questions regarding the completeness and correct indexing of digitised answer books.

The controversy showed that digital evaluation is far more than digitising answer books. It requires secure infrastructure, trained examiners, quality controls, and transparent verification. Failure at any stage can undermine trust in the system. Ironically, a reform aimed at enhancing transparency and accountability itself raised questions about transparency, verification, and trust.

Perhaps the most consequential flaw in the OSM rollout was the decision to charge for access to scanned answer scripts. Since answer books had already been digitised as part of the evaluation workflow, students were effectively being asked to pay to access and verify records that were largely their own intellectual work. This raises a fundamental question: why should students pay to inspect and verify answer scripts that had already been created and stored in digital form?

The fee-based access model also created avoidable technological and administrative problems. Students repeatedly encountered server overload, portal glitches, payment gateway failures, delayed script delivery, and difficulties accessing scanned answer books within limited time windows. Because access was restricted and linked to payment, large numbers of students attempted to download their scripts simultaneously, creating concentrated demand and congestion on the system.

More importantly, the approach missed an opportunity to build transparency directly into the evaluation process. Since answer scripts were already digitised before evaluation, CBSE could have securely shared encrypted digital copies with all students and parents by default through authenticated portals, email, or registered mobile applications. Students could then verify within a defined period that the scripts were complete, readable, correctly indexed, and genuinely theirs, including all supplementary sheets. Such a verification layer would likely have detected many issues at an early stage, including blurred scans, missing pages, wrongly uploaded scripts, and incomplete digitisation. It would also have distributed server load

more evenly, rather than concentrating access requests within a paid application window. In effect, a transparency-driven model could have reduced disputes, minimised technological failures, improved public confidence, and transformed millions of students into the first line of verification for the digital evaluation ecosystem.

Proposed National Digital Evaluation Model (NDEM)

The National Digital Evaluation Model (NDEM) can build upon the strengths of CBSE's OSM while addressing the weaknesses exposed during its rollout.

Digitisation: Under NDEM, answer scripts should first be scanned using standardised high-resolution infrastructure and securely archived with appropriate cybersecurity safeguards. Before evaluation begins, encrypted digital copies of answer scripts should be delivered free of cost to students and parents through authenticated portals, email, or registered mobile applications. Students should be given a limited verification window to confirm that the scripts are complete, readable, correctly indexed, and genuinely their own, including all supplementary sheets.

Digital Evaluation: Simultaneously, detailed subject-wise, step-wise marking schemes should be finalised and published. Once script verification is completed, evaluation should proceed through trained examiners using standardised digital platforms. Digital audit trails, centralised moderation, automated totalling checks, anomaly-detection systems, and random quality audits should continuously monitor consistency and compliance with prescribed SOPs.

Self-Verification: After evaluation, students would already possess both their answer scripts and the approved marking schemes. This would enable them to independently estimate their likely scores and compare them with officially awarded marks. Significant deviations could then trigger targeted review mechanisms, thereby reducing the need for large-scale re-evaluation requests.

Review: The model retains re-checking and re-evaluation as final safeguards but shifts the emphasis from post-result dispute resolution to pre-evaluation verification and transparency.

By combining secure technology, standardised evaluation, student verification, and digital accountability, NDEM can create a transparent, auditable, and trustworthy evaluation ecosystem for Board, university, admission, and recruitment examinations across India.

The success of MCQ-based examinations has shown that transparency, verification, and digital auditability strengthen public trust and system integrity. Descriptive evaluation must now evolve on similar principles.

The proposed National Digital Evaluation Model (NDEM) should be supported by robust SOPs, reliable scanning infrastructure, secure archival systems, high-capacity servers, structured examiner training, standardised step-wise marking schemes, strong cybersecurity safeguards, and automated audit mechanisms. Most importantly, scanned answer scripts should be securely provided free of cost to all students and parents, enabling verification of completeness, readability, and authenticity before evaluation begins.

By extending the transparency framework of MCQ-based examinations to descriptive assessments, NDEM can transform evaluation into a transparent, verifiable, auditable, and student-centric ecosystem. Importantly, the framework can be implemented immediately, helping address many issues exposed during the CBSE-OSM rollout. If adopted carefully, NDEM can become a national benchmark for digital evaluation and restore confidence in large-scale examination systems.

The writer is a Tech Education Policy Consultant, a former Professor of Computer Science at IIT Kharagpur, IIT Kanpur, BITS Pilani, and JNU, and a former scientist at DRDO and DST

 dailypioneer

 @rajeevkumar

 prof-rajeev-kumar-51679611

Why India's women athletes win differently



ISHANI SIROHI

When I stood on the podium as Kettlebell World Champion, people asked which training facility I came from. What sports science team supported me. What recovery protocols I followed. The honest answer surprised them: I had a coach who believed in me, a family rooted in Army discipline, and a hunger that no lab could have designed.

Both my parents served in the Indian Armed Forces. Growing up in that environment, fitness wasn't a lifestyle choice; it was a way of being. Pre-dawn drills weren't motivation. They were just Tuesday. That story, in different textures, is the story of almost every elite Indian woman in sport. It is not primarily a story of systems. It is a story of soul. And right now, India stands at a rare crossroads where that soul is finally beginning to meet the system it has always deserved.

"The West built the pipeline first and the athletes followed. India has always had the athletes. It is finally, urgently, building the pipeline."

The infrastructure gap between India and Western sporting nations is real, and it matters. Title IX, the landmark 1972 US legislation, banned gender discrimination in federally funded education - and its impact on women's sport was seismic. Before it passed, fewer than 295,000 girls competed in high-school sport in America. By 2019, that number had risen to 3.4 million.

Today, 60 per cent of American high-school girls participate in organised sport. Women now make up 44 per cent of all NCAA athletes, compared to under 16 per cent before 1972. Norway, the Netherlands, and Australia have invested for decades in gender-neutral coaching pipelines, sports nutrition, and physiotherapy access, often from as young as twelve. The result isn't just more women competing. It's women competing longer, better, and with far fewer career-ending injuries that come from undertrained, under-supported early years. In India, that support structure has historically been the exception, not the rule. Talent has too often been discovered after it already proved itself, which means untold numbers of girls never got the chance to prove it at all.

But the data doesn't capture everything. Mirabai Chanu grew up in Manipur carrying firewood for her family because they couldn't afford the bus. She became an Olympic silver medalist and world record holder in weightlifting. Deepika Kumari practised archery on handmade bamboo bows in Jharkhand before becoming world number one.

These are not feel-good footnotes. They are evidence of something the scoreboard doesn't show: the conditioning that comes from consequence. When failure isn't an option you philosophically reject but a reality you literally cannot afford, you develop a relationship with pressure that no training programme can manufacture. India's women athletes have been learning that lesson for generations.

The Women's Sports Foundation's landmark 2024 Play to Lead study, spanning seven generations of women athletes, confirmed what coaches here have known intuitively: girls who play sport develop leadership skills, emotional resilience, and decisiveness under pressure that last a lifetime. Seventy-one per cent of women with formal leadership titles - manager, director, C-suite - had been youth sport participants.

The field is not just a playing surface. It is a classroom for life. "Where Western athletes learn resilience as a studied skill, Indian athletes carry it as lived experience and then as a competitive edge."

For generations, the unspoken contract for ambitious Indian women was this: you may excel, but only in one direction. Career or family. Medals or motherhood. Public achievement or private fulfilment. Mary Kom simply refused to sign it, and did so in the most unambiguous terms. A six-time world boxing champion, an Olympic medalist, a daughter, a wife, and a mother of three. Not sequentially. Simultaneously. She is not an anomaly. She is a blueprint. The capacity to carry multiple heavy things at once, to train through exhaustion, to compete through doubt, to return to the ring after heartbreak, is not something a sports science lab teaches. It comes from life. And Indian women, by necessity and by character, have been training for it their entire lives.

Across India's cities, a quiet revolution is underway. Women who work full-time, raise families, and also train, not because they have the luxury of doing so, but because sport has become non-negotiable to who they are. They train at 5 a.m. They compete on week-ends. They mentor younger girls on evenings when most people are watching television. This hybrid model, where women fold sport into already full lives, is uniquely Indian in texture. Globally, elite sport tends to demand exclusivity: you either commit entirely or not at all. India's women are showing a third way.

And increasingly, formal structures are arriving to support it. The government's Khelo India initiative has opened national pathways for young athletes across genders and disciplines, with over 5,600 athletes competing across 36 states and union territories at the 2024 Youth Games alone. Corporate sponsorships are growing. Social media visibility has made stars of athletes from small towns who once trained entirely in anonymity. So is the gap between Indian and Western women athletes about genetics or biology? The science is clear: no. Athletic capacity does not follow national or ethnic lines. Kenyan and Ethiopian women dominate long-distance running. East Asian women lead in gymnastics and precision sports. India's Mirabai Chanu holds world records.

The differences are structural, not biological: pipeline, funding, access, and time. What changes when you take an athlete shaped by scarcity and give her access? The answer, playing out in real time across Indian sport, is that she becomes extraordinary. Not in spite of where she came from, but in some irreducible way, because of it. I have a coach. I have a support system. I am one of the luckier ones. But the foundation, the absolute refusal to quit, the understanding that discomfort is not a reason to stop, was built long before any of that arrived. It was built in cantonments, in pre-dawn runs, in a childhood that treated discipline not as punishment but as preparation. Multiply that story across the millions of girls in this country who are already running, lifting, throwing, and swimming, most of them with far less support than they deserve. India's sporting era is here - women are leading the way.

The writer is a Kettlebell World Champion and advocate for women in sport

 dailypioneer

 @TheDailyPioneer

 The Pioneer

Viksit Bharat demands an innovation revolution



AMITABH RANJAN

Yoga, Ayurveda, and the list goes on. However, it is now a nation that consumes innovation far more than it creates. While celebrating start-ups, unicorns, and IPOs, we have mastered the art of innovating peripherally but importing the crux.

The numbers do not lie. India spends only around 0.7 per cent of its GDP on Research and Development (R&D), a number that has remained almost the same over time, whereas developed nations like Israel and South Korea spend over 5 per cent. Even the USA and China spend over 3 per cent on R&D. This is becoming a structural handicap. While calling ourselves a knowledge economy, we are barely investing in knowledge.

Patents per million of population remain minuscule, while India produces millions of engineers every year. We are the software capital of the world but import hardware, chips, medical devices, etc. We host GCCs and global R&D hubs, but often for global headquarters rather than for indigenous innovation.

India's R&D debate is based on a dangerous

notion that innovation is the responsibility of the government alone. In developed economies across the globe, such as the USA, Japan, Germany, and China, R&D financing by the business sector exceeds 60 per cent. However, in India, the government is often seen as the main culprit if R&D is not taking off.

In crucial sectors such as defence, nuclear energy, space, DPL, and critical minerals, heavy government R&D spending is understandable. Recent measures under PM Modi, such as the establishment of ANRF and the RDI Fund, reflect the government's seriousness towards R&D. However, innovation is never only a state subject; it is primarily market-led.

Neither the smartphone was invented by any ministry, nor was the semiconductor revolution driven by subsidies alone. Even AI was not born inside government labs. Across the developed world, private capital bears risks that public finance cannot justify to voters.

And here lies India's paradox: Corporate India is cash-rich but research-poor. India Inc. sits on unprecedented cash reserves but has a limited appetite for long-term risk. Share buy-backs, dividends, real-estate expansion, and financial investments often take priority over deep research.

Why? Because innovation in India is structurally irrational. Not intellectually irrational, but economically irrational, as innovation requires three things: risk, time, and freedom. India's regulatory culture taxes all three, while companies face compliance burdens, slow approvals, policy unpredictability, and weak industry-academia collaboration. The result? Firms choose certainty over



curiosity. Why invest in uncertain deep tech when regulatory arbitrage, market dominance, or financial engineering deliver low-hanging fruit? India rewards scale. Innovation rewards uncertainty. Any guess which one boards prefer?

Subsidies vs science

Here lies the political reality policymakers rarely say aloud. In a democracy, governments must spend on areas such as social welfare, poverty alleviation, disaster management, infrastructure, health, education, and various subsidies. These are not optional but democratic obligations. Expecting the government to dramatically increase R&D spending while shouldering these responsibilities is wishful thinking in a developing democracy.

Innovation cannot be funded only by taxpayers when corporations sit on huge idle capital. India does not have an R&D spending problem. It has

a private-sector risk-appetite problem. And this threatens the notion of Viksit Bharat. Moreover, India loves the word jugaad. It celebrates frugal innovation, improvisation, and cost optimisation. However, frugality is not the same as innovative research. Jugaad produces incremental efficiency. R&D produces technological sovereignty.

Nations that invest and invent in futuristic fields such as AI, quantum computing, semiconductors, critical minerals, renewable energy, etc. will set the rules of trade, security, and geopolitics. Nations that do not will borrow the future. The transition from jugaad to genuine invention is the need of the hour.

The uncomfortable truth about Indian capitalism is that it has matured in a protected ecosystem characterised by high entry barriers in several sectors, market concentration in key industries, strong returns in infrastructure, finance, and services, and limited competition. In such an environment, the incentive to invest in risky R&D is low. Competition drives innovation. Market power reduces the need for it. Until competition becomes the prime mover of corporate growth, research will remain peripheral.

India does not need mere slogans about innovation, but incentives aligned with invention. This necessitates paradigm shifts, such as making R&D financially rational through stronger tax incentives tied to actual research output, public procurement that prioritises domestic innovation, and faster IP enforcement and patent processing.

Moreover, it is worthwhile to make risk culturally acceptable by encouraging corporate venture funding for deep tech, rewarding long-term R&D in stock-market valuations, and reforming the

bankruptcy stigma associated with failed innovation ventures. Additionally, universities and academic institutions should be groomed as engines of industry by incentivising industry-funded research chairs, permitting flexible hiring and pay structures in research institutions, and creating shared industry-academic laboratories. Innovation ecosystems are not built by policy documents alone, but by aligned incentives.

India is a fast-growing economy, but growth without innovation has limits. An economy can grow by adding labour, capital, and productivity. India has relied heavily on the first two, but sustained prosperity depends on the third. Without innovation, growth eventually slows.

Without invention, incomes stagnate and strategic autonomy weakens. The demographic dividend will not last forever, and cheap labour is not a permanent advantage. Innovation is the only long-term multiplier. The 20th century exhorted India to become independent; the 21st century asks it to become inventive. Government labs, start-ups, and academia cannot achieve this alone.

Corporate India must decide whether it wants to be merely wealthy or truly consequential for Viksit Bharat. Nations that stop inventing eventually start importing their destiny, and history rarely remembers those who only bought the future.

The writer is an alumnus of NES, Washington, DC, and IIT (ISM) Dhanbad, and is associated with the Indian Institute of Public Administration (IIPA), New Delhi, as Registrar

 dailypioneer

 @TheDailyPioneer

 dr-amitabh-ranjan-3601a210



TRANSGLOBE
ADVISORS

Your Trusted Management Advisory

www.transglobeadvisors.in



Order Order

SC gets five new judges; strength to go up to 37



Five new judges were on Monday appointed to the Supreme Court, which will now have 37 judges, one short of the upgraded sanctioned strength of 38.

According to separate notifications issued by the department of justice in the Union law ministry on Monday morning, senior SC advocate Venkita Subramani Mohana, Justice Shree Chandrashekar, Chief Justice of Bombay High Court, Justice Sheel Nagu, Chief Justice of Punjab and Haryana High Court, Justice Sanjeev Sachdeva, Chief Justice of Madhya Pradesh High Court, and Justice Arun Palli, Chief Justice of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh High Court have been elevated as top court judges.

Once they take oath and assume charge, the SC will formally have 37 judges.

The Government last month promulgated an ordinance amending a law to increase the sanctioned strength of the apex court to 38 from 34, including the Chief Justice of India.

While there were already two vacancies, after the sanctioned strength was increased, altogether six posts became vacant in the apex court.

With five appointments on Monday, the Supreme Court has one vacancy.

The five names were recommended by the Supreme Court Collegium on May 27 and the appointments came through in four days. (PTI)

SC notice to Centre on plea seeking compliance with recommendations of disability commissions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday sought the Centre's response on a plea seeking guidelines on effective and time-bound compliance by authorities with the recommendations of disability commissions. A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and PB Varale issued a notice on a public interest litigation filed by Shashank Pandey, a lawyer, and asked the Centre to respond to it.

The plea, filed through advocate Talha Abdul Rahman, has sought the apex court's intervention to address the implementation gaps in the grievance redressal mechanism as provided in the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016.

Advocate Rahul Bajaj appeared for the petitioner in



the matter. The bench posted the matter for hearing on July 21 and tagged the plea with another pending petition raising similar issue.

The plea said the Act provides for appointment of chief commissioner and state commissioners for persons with disabilities and both these offices were intended to function as mon-

itoring and quasi-judicial authorities for ensuring protection of rights of persons with disabilities.

The plea said as per the provisions of the Act, the chief and state commissioners have been given the power to make recommendations, which the authorities concerned are mandated to comply with within three

months. It said the authorities may refuse to comply with the recommendations so long as they furnish the reasons for the same to the disability commission and the aggrieved person.

"In practice, however, the data reveals that in a large majority of cases, authorities choose neither to comply with the recommendations of the disability commissions nor do they provide any justification for the same," the plea said. It referred to Section 93 of the Act which deals with punishment for failure to furnish information.

"While recommendations of the CCPD (Chief Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities) refer to the possibility of imposing Section 93 in case the requisite information is not furnished, in practice such a fine is never imposed," the plea said.

Kerala HC admits CMRL appeal against ED probe, stays action till June 5

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

The Kerala High Court on Monday admitted an appeal filed by CMRL against a single-judge verdict that allowed the ED to continue its money laundering investigation into the company's financial dealings with Veena T, daughter of former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan.

A Division Bench comprising Justice Raja Vijayaraghavan and Justice KV Jayakumar heard the matter and posted it for judgment on June 5. The Enforcement Directorate (ED) told the High Court that it would refrain from taking any precipitative action in connection with the matter until June 5, when the appeal is scheduled for judgment.

Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd challenged the May 26 single-judge verdict, which held that the ED could proceed with its investigation under the Prevention of



Money Laundering Act even before the Serious Fraud Investigation Office filed a formal FIR or final report.

In its appeal, CMRL argued that the judgment caused it prejudice, stating that the case had been reserved for orders twice, in 2024 and 2025. The company also alleged that the ED was not given an opportunity to respond to them.

The additional affidavits

referred to an SFIO complaint filed in April 2025, alleging offences under the Companies Act, including fraud-related provisions that qualify as scheduled offences under the PMLA.

CMRL contended that it was denied a hearing on whether the later SFIO complaint could be used to justify an ED investigation that had begun when no scheduled offence existed.

It claimed this amounted to a violation of the principles of natural justice.

Temporary staff can't do regular work in precarious jobs: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Taking strong note of acute dissimilarity in perks and retirement benefits of temporary and regular employees, the Supreme Court on Monday said that the State as an employer cannot retain a workforce which does the same work as permanent staff but is denied corresponding benefits.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and AG Masih set aside an order of the Patna High Court that denied pensionary benefits to temporary employees who have served for decades in the Department of Post.

The top court said any classification resulting in denial of any benefits to a class of employees who are otherwise similarly situated in terms of duties and responsibilities would fall foul of constitutional ethos.

The bench said this court has taken a consistent judicial approach that long-serving employees, whether casual or temporary, partic-

ularly those who have been conferred recognised status, cannot be denied corresponding benefits including social security and pensionary benefits.

"The emphasis must be on ensuring that the State does not retain such employees in a precarious condition while extracting services identical to those performed by regular employees," it said.

The bench directed the Centre to compute and release within three months the pensionary and consequential retiral benefits payable to a group of former employees or legal representatives of the employees who had rendered long years of service under the Department of Posts as casual labourers (Night Guards).

It said, in case of default, interest at the rate of six per cent per annum from the date of accrual till disbursement shall be payable to such persons.

The bench noted that notwithstanding the conferment of temporary status and the extension of benefits



akin to Group 'D' employees, the former employees or legal heirs of such employees were never formally regularised in service mainly due to administrative inaction on the part of the Department of Posts.

"The Directive Principles of State Policy, particularly Articles 38, 39 and 43, cast a positive obligation upon the State to ensure social and economic justice, fair conditions of work, and a decent standard of life for labourers. Pension, in this context, is not

a gratuitous benefit but a facet of social welfare and economic justice," it said.

The top court said the concept of the State as a model employer, read in conjunction with the aforesaid constitutional mandate, reinforces the obligation upon the State to extend fair and equitable treatment to employees who have rendered long and continuous service and that the State cannot extract services of a permanent nature while denying corresponding benefits.

"At this stage, it is also necessary to note that pension is not a bounty but a vested and enforceable constitutional right," the top court underscored, while referring to a 2013 verdict, which held that pension is a hard-earned benefit amassed by an employee by virtue of long and continuous service and is in the nature of "property" within the meaning of Article 300A of the Constitution.

It said once pension is recognised as a constitutional right in the nature of property, it cannot be taken away except by authority of law.

"A statutory right cannot be rendered illusory on account of inaction of the employer, and such inaction cannot defeat or deny a constitutional right.

"It is in the light of this above discussed judicial approach of this court over a period of time, the provisions of the Scheme and the subsequent applicable circulars must be read, understood and interpreted," the top court said.



NEET row: 3 accused sent to 14-day judicial custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Monday sent three accused accused in the NEET paper leak case — a physics lecturer empanelled by the National Testing Agency (NTA) as translator, a Latur-based paediatrician and a physics tutor — to 14 days' judicial custody.

Special Judge Ajay Gupta allowed the CBI's plea seeking judicial custody of physics translator Manisha Sanjay Hawaldar, paediatrician Dr Manoj Shirure and physics teacher Tejas Harshadkumar Shah.

Hawaldar's CBI custody was extended by two days on Saturday, while Shirure and Shah were sent to five days of custodial interrogation on May 27.

CBI alleged that Hawaldar, in conspiracy with other accused persons, without authorisation kept and distributed the NEET-UG examination paper for money.

It alleged that Manoj Shirure played a "key role"



in facilitating three students, including the son of Shivraj Raghunath Motegaonkar, who runs the Renukai Chemistry Classes (RCC) in Maharashtra's Latur, in getting Chemistry questions from NEET paper setter P V Kulkarni.

The agency had already arrested Motegaonkar and Kulkarni, the alleged kingpin, in the case.

Tejas Harshadkumar Shah, a Physics teacher at Dr Abhang Prabhu Medical Academy (APMA), a Pune-based coaching centre, was

also arrested for his involvement in the case.

According to the federal agency, Shah allegedly received the leaked Physics questions for NEET UG 2026 from Hawaldar.

CBI has arrested 13 accused persons in the case. On May 12, the NTA cancelled the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET, held on May 3 for medical admissions amid allegations of paper leak. A re-examination has been scheduled for June 21.

NEET-UG CBT retest plea dismissed by SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday refused to accept a plea seeking the conduct of the NEET-UG 2026 re-test on June 21 in computer-based test mode, saying the National Testing Agency is already faced with too many problems.

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Aravind Kumar, which posted the plea by RJD MP Sudhakar Singh and others for hearing on July 27, refused to order the conduct of the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET-UG, in Computer-Based Test (CBT) mode instead of the existing pen-and-paper method.

On May 12, the National Testing Agency (NTA) cancelled the NEET-UG held on May 3 for medical admissions amid allegations of paper leak.

The CBI is currently investigating the matter, and a retest is scheduled for June



21. "There is no question of conducting the re-examination in CBT mode. They (the NTA) are already having too many problems. The examination was cancelled, and now it is being re-conducted. Either we dismiss this petition now or after the vacation," the bench told advocate Satyam Singh Rajput, appearing for the petitioners.

At the outset, Rajput said they are not pressing any other prayer but only one related to conducting the re-test in CBT mode.

Venkita Mohana becomes second woman to be directly elevated to SC from Bar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior advocate Venkita Subramani Mohana, who was appointed a judge in the Supreme Court on Monday, has become only the second woman in the country to be directly elevated to the apex court from the Bar after Justice Indu Malhotra in 2018.

Mohana will be one of the two serving women judges in the Supreme Court alongside Justice BV Nagarathna, who has been a judge in the top court since August 31, 2021. Justice Nagarathna will also become the Chief Justice of India for more than a month in 2027.

Mohana, 59, graduated from the Coimbatore Law College in 1988 and has been practising since then. The Supreme Court designated her as a senior advocate in 2015.



She has appeared in several high-profile cases, including matters related to permanent commission for women officers in the armed forces, senior citizens' property rights, and the Karnataka hijab ban case. Mohana will be the 12th woman judge in the history of the Supreme Court, and the second to be elevated directly from the Bar. She will retire in June 2031.

Justice M Fathima Beevi was the first woman appointed to the Supreme Court in 1989. She was elevated after serving as a high court judge.

At one point, when Justice Indu Malhotra was a judge, the Supreme Court had three women judges, with Justice R Banumathi and Justice Indira Banerjee being the other two.

Malhotra was sworn in as a top court judge directly from the Bar on April 27, 2018. She retired in March 2021. There are presently two other judges in the top court who have been elevated directly from the Bar — Justices PS Narasimha and KV Viswanathan. Mohana's appointment is significant from a gender-representation perspective. Last month, the Government promulgated an ordinance amending a law to increase the sanctioned strength of the apex court from 34 to 38, including the Chief Justice of India.

While there were already two vacancies, after the sanctioned strength was increased, a total of six posts became vacant in the apex court. With the five appointments made on Monday, the Supreme Court now has one vacancy.

On May 27, the Supreme Court Collegium had recommended the five names.

SC questions Waqf institution's plea for court fees exemption in tribunals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday questioned the legal basis for exempting waqf institutions from payment of court fees in proceedings before State Waqf Tribunals.

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Aravind Kumar made the remarks while hearing a plea against an order of the Gujarat High Court that upheld the rejection of waqf suits for non-payment of court fees by relying on its earlier ruling that Waqf institutions are not exempt from paying court fees before the State Waqf Tribunal.

Advocate Ejaz Maqbool, appearing for petitioners, sought time to file additional documents challenging the Gujarat High Court's December 2025 decision.



Justice Narasimha, however, questioned Maqbool about the basis of the claim for exemption from court fees. "How can there be an exemption? What is the law that allows you to seek an exemption from court fees?" he asked.

Maqbool responded that the petitioners would address the issue in detail and urged the court to defer the hearing to August 7.

On December 17, 2025, the Gujarat High Court dis-

missed a batch of petitions filed by waqf institutions challenging the Gujarat State Waqf Tribunal's orders rejecting proceedings over disputes relating to waqf properties on account of insufficient court fees.

The court held that there is no blanket exemption or waiver available to waqf institutions from payment of court fees for proceedings instituted under Section 83 of the Waqf Act before the Gujarat State Waqf Tribunal.

PIOTECH

Haldwani forest division uses AI to monitor birds



In a first-of-its-kind initiative, Haldwani forest division has launched an innovative bird monitoring initiative using advanced wildlife acoustic recorders and AI-based analysis for scientific assessment of avian biodiversity, a senior official said on Monday.

Under this initiative, automated wildlife acoustic recorders are being deployed in forest areas to continuously capture natural sounds and bird calls from the environment, Haldwani Divisional Forest Officer (DFO) Kundan Kumar said.

These devices are capable of recording sounds round-the-clock with minimal human disturbance, he said.

“Since every bird species has unique vocal signatures and call patterns, the recorded audio data can be analysed using AI-based software to identify species and assess their occurrence and activity. The collected audio recordings will be processed using machine learning and deep learning algorithms capable of analysing thousands of hours of acoustic data in a short time,” Kumar said.

The system can help identify bird species, estimate their presence and relative abundance, understand activity patterns and generate valuable scientific insights regarding habitat use and biodiversity status.

“Haldwani forest division considers this initiative an important step towards integrating modern technology with wildlife conservation in Uttarakhand. Use of wildlife acoustic recorder and artificial intelligence (AI)/machine learning-based technology for bird monitoring is being done for the first time in Uttarakhand,” he said. (PTI)

Heavy industries adopt engineering to cut emissions



Industries across the mining, metals, chemical and manufacturing sectors are increasingly adopting precision engineering, wastewater treatment and resource recovery technologies to improve productivity and reduce carbon emissions, experts said.

As India seeks to balance economic growth with environmental sustainability, these moves reflect a broader push to modernise industrial processes while meeting climate and resource-efficiency goals.

Industry experts say this reflects a broader shift in corporate thinking, with sustainability increasingly being integrated into operational efficiency, risk management and long-term business strategy rather than being viewed solely as a compliance requirement.

The economic rationale is becoming increasingly compelling. India generates around 72,368 million litres of sewage every day, yet only a fraction is ultimately treated and reused.

Industry observers believe wastewater recovery and reuse will play an important role in strengthening water security while reducing pressure on freshwater resources.

KEP Engineering Services, led by Managing Director Malu Kamble, has been working in the field of industrial liquid waste management and resource recovery. The company has commissioned more than 650 plants across 550 companies spanning over 35 sectors, helping industries recover water and improve environmental performance. (PTI)

Can AI pass Gandhi’s talisman? Inside India’s ₹25,530-crore SARTHAK-PDS gamble

How NIRMAL, SAKSHAM and ASHA will work?



NISHANT SAHDEV

In the closing days of his life, Mahatma Gandhi offered the leaders of a nascent India a moral compass, famously known as his Talisman. “Recall the face of the poorest and the weakest man whom you may have seen,” he advised, “and ask yourself if the step you contemplate is going to be of any use to him.”

For nearly eight decades, the Indian state has attempted to operationalise this empathy through the Public Distribution System (PDS) — a heavily subsidised logistical leviathan designed to ensure that no citizen starves. Yet, human administration is inherently with imperfection. Getting food from Government silos to a family’s plate is full of hurdles, like stolen grain, fake accounts, and tech failures.

On May 27, 2026, the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs fundamentally shifted how the Government handles these inefficiencies. Backed by a ₹25,530-crore budget through March 2031, the SARTHAK-PDS scheme goes far beyond basic digitisation. By integrating AI, machine learning, natural language processing, and blockchain directly into the National Food Security Act, the Indian Government is attempting something historic: entrusting an algorithm to execute Gandhi’s Talisman and protect the nation’s poorest

As an AI strategist who has studied digital infrastructure rollouts across the globe, I view this not just as a policy update, but as the most consequential technological gamble of India’s chapter.

The economic and strategic logic behind SARTHAK-PDS is immaculate. The scheme smartly consolidates the financial margins of over 500,000 Fair Price Shop (FPS) dealers and intra-state transport costs into a unified framework. When a ration shop is financially viable, the economic incentive to divert Government grain plummets.

But the real game-changer is the technology itself. The Government is rolling out three core AI platforms: NIRMAL to automatically weed out fake accounts, SAKSHAM to track and optimise the supply chain in real time, and ASHA, a multilingual assistant for resolving citizen complaints. If successful, this ₹25,530-crore investment will pay for itself. By optimising logistics and minimising theft, the state will save hundreds of crores annually while reducing the carbon footprint of its supply chains. India is poised to build a welfare architecture that dwarfs the United Nations’ localised blockchain aid programs or Brazil’s AI — driven social security nets.

But there’s a massive gap between a flawless algorithm in a Delhi server room and a glitchy fingerprint scanner in a dusty Jharkhand village. Code is clean; reality is messy. If SARTHAK-PDS fails, it won’t be because the technology is bad, but because it ignored the harsh, on-the-ground realities of India. To stop this massive upgrade from becoming a nightmare for the poor, we have to urgently fix the blind spots where the tech actually meets the people.

The tragedy of calloused thumb

The most glaring vulnerability in India’s



tech-welfare stack is the biometric exclusion trap. Our distribution architecture is inextricably linked to fingerprint authentication via electronic Point of Sale (e-Pos) devices. Yet, the primary beneficiaries of the PDS — construction workers, agricultural farmers, and manual laborers — earn their bread through physical toil. Decades of hard labor literally erase their biometric footprints.

When an e-Pos device repeatedly rejects a calloused thumb, the digital system logs a “fraudulent attempt”. The blockchain ledger remains pristine, the system registers zero leakage, but a legitimate citizen is turned away empty-handed. We cannot allow an AI system to starve a citizen simply because their labor has worn away their digital identity.

To dismantle this trap, the SARTHAK-PDS rollout must mandate multi-modal authentication across the entire FPS network. e-Pos machines must be universally equipped with iris scanning capabilities and UIDAI’s face-authentication technology. More importantly, we must institutionalise a digital “Nominee Protocol”. If a beneficiary suffers from chronic biometric failure, they must have the unalienable right to digitally nominate a trusted community member — a neighbour or relative — whose biometrics can trigger the release of their rations.

The illusion of blockchain

The scheme places immense faith in Blockchain to secure the supply chain. Blockchain is heralded for its immutability; once a transaction is verified, it cannot be secretly altered. This is a brilliant defense against data tampering, but it has some problems too. SAKSHAM’s GPS tracking and cryptographic ledgers can mathematically guarantee that a truck carrying premium grain traveled from a depot directly to the local dealer without unauthorised detours.

But what stops a corrupt intermediary from physically opening those QR-coded sacks upon arrival, siphoning off the high-quality rice, and replacing it with rotting, substandard grain? The blockchain will



happily report a 100 per cent successful, untampered delivery, providing a high-tech smokescreen for a low-tech crime.

Bits cannot secure atoms. To bridge this gap, we must deploy the Internet of Things (IoT) at the grassroots. Every transit vehicle must be equipped with IoT-enabled Smart Locks that can only be unlocked via a localised digital handshake with the authorised receiving dealer’s device. Furthermore, AI vision tools must be integrated into the dealer’s workflow. A simple smartphone photograph of the received sacks should allow an AI to instantly read the batch details and assess grain quality, verifying that the physical asset matches the digital ledger before it ever reaches the public.

The algorithmic panopticon

Machine learning models, like those powering NIRMAL, thrive on identifying deviations from the norm. Under the brilliant “One Nation, One Ration Card” framework, a migrant worker from Bihar working in Mumbai might suddenly withdraw three months of accumulated rations for their family in one go.

To an improperly calibrated AI trained to hunt for welfare fraud, this sudden, high-volume cross-state transaction looks highly suspicious. If the algorithm is empowered to automatically freeze the dealer’s or the citizen’s account, it places the burden of proof on the destitute. They are forced into a Kafkaesque bureaucratic maze to prove the AI wrong, all while their food supply is severed.

Algorithms must be relegated to the role of auditors, never executors. SARTHAK-PDS must enforce a strict “Human-in-the-Loop” (HITL) protocol. If an AI flags a transaction as anomalous, the account should

be marked for urgent administrative review, but the food supply must never be interrupted. This is where the ASHA AI assistant must be weaponised for empathy. Instead of just answering queries, ASHA should proactively call citizens in their local dialects if their status is under review, offering an instant, one-click voice appeal to a human district officer.

The myth of ubiquitous connectivity

In remote tribal belts, mountainous terrains, or during frequent rural internet blackouts, an e-Pos machine without a signal becomes a useless brick. If the system defaults to “deny access when offline” in the name of security, the technology transforms from an enabler of survival into a direct barrier to it. The entire e-Pos network must be rebuilt on a “Store-and-Forward” cryptographic architecture. The machines must be capable of authenticating a beneficiary offline — using encrypted local caches or smart card chips — and disbursing the ration immediately. Once the dealer moves the machine back into a connectivity zone, the system can bulk — upload and synchronise the ledger. Resilience must always take precedence over real-time tracking.

The ultimate test of statecraft

Ultimately, this ₹25,530-crore investment is about more than just buying new tech. It’s a test to see if a Government system can be both automated and compassionate.

Technology is just the plumbing; empathy is what actually matters. We won’t judge the success of SARTHAK-PDS by how fancy its code or blockchain is. We’ll judge it by what happens when a laborer with worn-out fingerprints tries to get their ration in a village with no internet. If the system still recognises them and hands over their food, it works.

If India can build AI that genuinely serves the most vulnerable, we won’t just feed 813 million people — we’ll show the world how to build technology with a conscience.

The writer is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems

Viksit skill revolution: India’s gateway to achieve skill capital



DR T SENTHIL SIVA SUBRAMANIAN

India’s progressive growth in Industrial Revolution:

Viksit Industrial Revolution

Industrial revolution has evolved from millions of years back to 18th century to 21st century undergoing huge transformative changes from powerful stone age to steam engine to automation and now world sees AI and Chip revolution which stands to be the Viksit Industrial Revolution for India’s 2047.

India might have missed the earlier industrial revolution buses. But the launch of several mission policies which include India AI mission, Indian Semi conductor Mission, and path breaking events like vibrant Global AI summit, pioneering AI Pillar start up like Sarvam AI and Gyan AI have re written the history of AI traits for our nation that formed the guiding spirit for the globe. Today is an era of Generative Artificial Intelligence and Agentic AIs. India has decoded hardest Large Language Models through simple ease of learning framework such as AI for ALL.

Skill: Need of the hour for Youth

Skilling forms vital and integral part of career development and growth of our nation. Skilling from basic trades such as welding, plumbing, electrical wiring, construction to advanced trades, which

include AI and chip making reshapes career goals and enables to develop a holistic feature both hard and soft skills among youth. These soft skills include adopting frugal methods for problem solving, solid foundation of creativity, life-long curious learning, adding emotions to design thinking, developing empathy and emotional intelligence cultivates resilience in young minds. Our nation is marching toward capturing the global ranking in skilling there by becoming the skill capital of the globe. As a part of Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship, Government of India, reskilling, and up skilling becomes significant component of National Education Policy 2020 that lead to credit linked and qualification frameworks.

These models and frameworks have been initiated through introduction of computation thinking starting from elementary schooling like class third to advanced large language models in higher studies.

World sees India as skill capital: Emerging skill infrastructure in India

Every state in India has been enormously contributing to the skill mission through state owned robust policy frameworks aligned with Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship. Government of India, Government of Gujarat in collaboration with Larson and Toubro has established India’s largest skill training centre at Vadnagar, Gujarat which is the hometown of Prime Minister of India Shri Narendra Modi.



L&T has opened various emerging avenues for the youth starting from the age of 18 to 35 through this globally recognised best — in class training institute called the Industrial Construction Skill Training Institute. The primary objective of the centre is to empower the unemployed young people with innovative skills in different traits spanning from cable, welding, civil construction, electrical wiring, and plumbing that leads to meeting the current job opportunities. The centre has a well — established training infrastructure integrated with innovative modern equipment, software, and hardware set-up. The



training includes simulation tools to simulate the replicate of the industrial setup. This training institute provides experiential learning through hand-on practical training to meet the demands of present job trends. Students from different streams are provided with the opportunity to work in hi-tech innovative Ahmedabad-Mumbai bullet train

projects. Home-grown training makes the students to be capable of working in metro projects which demand expertise in signal access control, managing public address systems, and managing CCTV surveillance systems.

The skilling curriculum frameworks are smartly structured which is in synergy with Level 2, Level 3, and Level 4 of National Skill Qualification Frameworks, NSQF. The students are offered globally aligned twenty different trades and traits which include carpentry, welding, pipe fitting, solar technician, Industrial Internet of Things, telecom and many more. The duration

of the in — house training program varies from 45 to 90 days. The training institute has successful tangible outcomes in the form of pilot batches graduated and employed in India’s prominent state of the infrastructure projects. The centre provides training free of cost and arranges boarding and lodging facilities for students across India.

Viksit skill era

India’s Viksit Era is moving towards building massive digital public infrastructures and research innovation parks such as highways, industrial corridors, Marine ports, power grids, floating solar installations, railway infrastructures like Vande Bharat, hydrogen powered buses and trains, hydrogen valleys, semi conductor valleys, quantum valley, AI data centre, textile parks and many more. The world class industrial skill training institute will form a strong backbone to support in building the infrastructures with the support of talented youth and young minds.

India is sailing towards Viksit Era by breaking various technological barrier through building bricks through strong talent pool. India is harnessing the potential of Youth who are the game changers of our nation. Skilling forms the backbone of building bold young minds. India is moulding youth to be Skill ready workforce to develop home grown Swadeshi products and solutions.

The writer is a Head Institute Industry Interface Program, Hindustan College of Science and Technology, Mathura

RO 45794-I-27-7

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

Exports growth in double digit in April-May: Official

The country's exports have recorded a double-digit growth during April-May 2026-27, a senior Government official said on Monday.

The Commerce Ministry will release the trade data for May on June 15.

"During the two months, exports are in double-digit growth," the official said.

Exports rose by 13.78 per cent to \$43.56 billion in April, the highest monthly outbound shipments in more than four years, driven by petroleum products amid a surge in crude oil prices, but the trade deficit widened to a three-month high of \$28.38 billion due to an uptick in imports.

The official also said that the commerce ministry will be hiring 1,000 people from across the country to disseminate information about free trade agreements being finalised by India.

"We need people from different languages," the official said, adding paperwork is underway for the hiring process.

India has implemented FTAs with the UAE, Oman, Australia, the EFTA bloc and Mauritius. It has also finalised these pacts with the UK, New Zealand and the EU.

(PTI)

2nd global tender issued for 70 lakh tonnes of urea imports

The Government has issued a second global tender for the import of 17 lakh tonne of urea despite a sharp rise in global prices to boost domestic supplies for the kharif season, a senior Fertiliser Ministry official said on Monday.

The global price of urea has increased from \$447 per tonne in February to 947 per tonne now, said Aparna S Sharma, additional secretary in the Fertiliser Ministry, during the inter-ministerial briefing on the recent developments in West Asia.

The country has secured 25 lakh tonne of urea and 50 lakh tonne of DAP from sources outside the Strait of Hormuz, with arrivals expected in June-July.

"We have also issued a global tender for 17 lakh tonne of urea, which is in progress. This is the second tender for the kharif season. The price in the global tender is yet to be discovered," Sharma said.

The domestic fertiliser production stood at 104.81 lakh tonne amid the West Asia crisis, while imports were 27.62 lakh tonne, taking total additions to availability to approximately 132.43 lakh tonne.

Factoring in the El Nino outlook, the agriculture ministry has revised fertiliser demand estimates downward in consultation with state governments.

Urea demand for the kharif 2026-27 season is pegged at 194 lakh tonne, lower by 4 lakh tonne, while di-ammonium phosphate (DAP) demand has been cut by 6 lakh tonne to 60 lakh tonne, she added.

Kharif (summer) sowing has just begun in some parts of India, but it is still in the very early stages. Farmers have started preparing fields for early sowing (especially of short-duration crops like pulses, coarse cereals, and some cotton) in regions that have received pre-monsoon rains.

(PTI)

Indian workers take less leave than APAC peers: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Indian employees take fewer annual leaves than their peers in Asia-Pacific markets despite having relatively generous leave entitlements, emphasising a gap between leave allocation and usage, a report said on Monday.

While leave is available, Indian workers appear more cautious in how they use it, with time off often taken in smaller increments rather than as extended vacations, revealed a report by HR and payroll company Deel.

The report is based on inputs from over 4,500 full-time workers on Deel APAC

platform in 2025. It further revealed that the median leave taken by Indian workers in 2025 was 12 days.

Only 17.2 per cent of Indian workers used 100 per cent of their leave, compared with 57.2 per

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | JUNE 2, 2026

Centre forms crisis groups for Kharif crops

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amid forecasts of a below-normal monsoon due to El Nino, the Centre on Monday said the Agriculture Ministry has formed crop weather watch and crisis management groups, besides circulating a crisis management plan to State Governments, to mitigate risks to kharif crops.

The Inter-Ministerial briefing, held in the context of recent developments in West Asia, also addressed concerns around food and fertiliser security.

States have been asked to maintain a seed reserve of one per cent, with empha-

sis on short and medium duration varieties.

Fertiliser stocks stand at 51 per cent of requirement for the kharif season — well above the conventionally maintained 33 per cent — owing to advance stocking and improved logistics management. The India Meteorological Department's latest southwest monsoon forecast stands at about 90 per cent of normal, flagging a below-normal season and heightened crop-risk pressure, particularly if El Nino conditions strengthen later in the season.

"A crop weather watch group has been constituted and meets every Monday to

study rainfall patterns, sowing progress, reservoir status, input availability, pest incidence and price trends," said Anupam Mishra, Additional Secretary, Food and Consumer Affairs Ministry. A separate

crisis management group comprising relief commissioners and state disaster management authorities has also been set up.

The agriculture ministry is preparing district contin-

Seamless pipe industry urges PM to curb imports

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Industry body STMAI has urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to take steps to curb rising imports of seamless pipes, particularly from China, warning that unchecked inflows are eroding domestic capacity utilisation and causing a substantial outflow of foreign exchange.

The development assumes significance in the wake of Prime Minister Modi's call for energy conservation and austerity measures amid the West Asia crisis.

In a representation to the Prime Minister, Seamless Tube Manufacturers' Association of India (STMAI) said India's installed seamless pipe manufacturing

capacity stands at about 1.95 million tonnes per annum. However, fluctuating domestic demand and a sharp rise in imports, particularly from China and other countries, have led to sustained under-utilisation of the country's manufacturing base.

"Over the past several years, the Association has continuously represented these concerns before the Ministry of Steel, Ministry of Commerce, Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI), Directorate General of Trade Remedies (DGTR), and other

concerned authorities. However, despite repeated representations, imports continue to rise steadily, adversely affecting domestic industry and leading to increased foreign exchange outflow," STMAI said.

Further, the Indian seamless pipe industry is predominantly utilising domestically manufactured steel for production, thereby strengthening the entire steel and manufacturing value chain in the country, while once again conserving valuable foreign exchange reserves, it said.

"In view of the above, we humbly request your kind intervention and support for the measures in the larger national interest," the industry body said.

Power consumption grows 11.55% to 164.98 billion units in May

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's power consumption grew 11.55 per cent year-on-year to 164.98 Billion Units (BU) in May, as heat wave conditions across the country pushed usage of cooling appliances like air conditioners and desert coolers, according to official data.

The country's total power consumption was 147.89 BU in May 2025.

The peak power demand jumped to an all-time record high of 270.82 GW last month from 230.99 GW recorded in May 2025 amid heat wave conditions. The peak power demand touched an all-time record high for four days in a row in May this year.

The peak power demand was at a record high of 257.37 GW on May 18, 260.45 GW on May 19, 265.44 GW on May 20 and 270.82 GW on May 21.

The peak power demand was at a record high of 256.11 GW on April 25. Earlier, the peak power demand had touched an all-time high of about 250 GW in May 2024.

According to the power ministry, peak power demand was projected to hit 270 GW in the summer of 2026.

Last summer, the peak power demand was 242.77 GW, recorded in June 2025, but stayed below the Government's estimate of 277 GW.

Oman offers India trade route beyond Strait of Hormuz: GTRI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The trade pact with Oman holds strategic significance for India, as much of Muscat's coastline lies outside the Strait of Hormuz, unlike other Gulf nations, enabling it to remain a reliable trade and energy gateway for India even during regional conflicts, disruptions or geopolitical instability, think tank GTRI said on Monday.

In that sense, the pact is not just a trade agreement but also an investment in India's long-term energy and economic security, it added.

The Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) between India and Oman, which was signed in December last year, will come into force from June 1. The Global Trade

Research Initiative (GTRI) said that Oman has a population of 55 lakh and a GDP of about \$110 billion and hence trade gains to India will remain modest.

However, the importance of the agreement lies in Oman's location.

Steel, CBAM issues sticking point in India-UK trade pact: Sources

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and the UK will discuss Britain's steel safeguard measure and Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) this week as these issues have become a sticking point in the implementation of the bilateral free trade pact, which was signed on July 24, 2025, sources said.

These issues will figure prominently during the UK Secretary of State for Business and Trade Peter Kyle's visit to India on June 2.

He will hold a bilateral meeting with Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal.

These issues have become a kind of sticking point in the implementation of the Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA). Both issues will be discussed during Kyle's visit, they said, indicating that until these issues are resolved, the rollout of the pact would be difficult.

From July 1, 2026, the UK will

limit tariff-free steel imports, reducing overall quota volumes by 60 per cent compared to the steel safeguard measure. Any imports above these levels will then face a 50 per cent tariff. The measure will apply to imports of steel products that can also be made in the UK.

Earlier, Britain had safeguard measures that also imposed import quotas. The new measures reduce that quota. The UK Government in

December 2023 also decided to implement its Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) starting in 2027.

According to economic think tank GTRI, India's exports worth \$775 million to the UK may be impacted due to Britain's decision to introduce a carbon tax on products like iron and steel, aluminium, fertiliser and cement, from 2027.

'BRICS nations need knowledge sharing in livestock sector'

Union Minister for Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying
Rajiv Ranjan Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister for Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying Rajiv Ranjan Singh on Monday called for collective actions and knowledge sharing among BRICS countries to strengthen the livestock sector, and stressed on finding innovative solutions to tackle challenges like animal disease and feed shortage.

The Department of Animal Husbandry & Dairying organised a high-level dialogue on 'Advanced Livestock Technology & Feed Systems (ALT&FS)' under the BRICS Agricultural Working Group in virtual mode, according to an official statement.

Singh highlighted the vital role of the livestock sector in supporting rural livelihoods, women empowerment, and nutritional security across BRICS nations.

He emphasised the need to address "challenges such as low productivity, feed shortages, animal diseases, and climate change through innovation and sustainable solutions".

The minister underscored the importance of knowledge-sharing and collective actions among BRICS countries to build resilient and sustainable livestock systems. The dialogue would strengthen cooperation and foster meaningful partnerships in the livestock sector, he added.

SP Singh Baghel, Minister of State for Fisheries, Animal Husbandry & Dairying, called for enhanced collaboration and knowledge-sharing among BRICS countries to build inclusive, sustainable, and farmer-centric livestock sectors. Naresh Pal Gangwar, Secretary in the department, emphasised the importance of quality feed, innovation, and scientific collaboration to strengthen sustainable livestock development.

Varsha Joshi, Additional Secretary (Cattle & Dairy) in the department, stressed the continued cooperation among BRICS nations to promote livestock technologies, sustainable feed systems, innovation, and knowledge sharing for building a resilient livestock sector.

Anant Raj signs pact with Haryana Govt to invest ₹20,000 cr on data centre

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Realty firm Anant Raj Ltd has signed an agreement with the Haryana Government to invest ₹20,000 crore for the development of data centre infrastructure in the State.

In a statement on Monday, the company said it has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Haryana government to invest ₹20,000 crore in the development of large-scale data centre infrastructure across the state.

Anant Raj currently operates 28 MW of IT load across its campuses in Manesar and

Panchkula and is expanding its data centre footprint across Haryana. It aims to achieve a total capacity of 307 MW by 2031-32 across Manesar, Panchkula and Rai, supported

by a planned capital expenditure of about \$2.1 billion.

The proposed investment is over and above the company's existing and ongoing data centre expansion plans. The MoU was signed during the launch of the 'Make in Haryana Policy' and other sectoral policies organised by the Department of Industries & Commerce, Government of Haryana.

The event was chaired by Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini in the presence of Rao Narbir Singh, the Minister of Industries & Commerce, Environment, Forests & Wildlife, Haryana.

Tribal affairs ministry, BPCL set up 75 space labs in tribal schools across India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

In a major push to strengthen science and technology education among tribal students, the Ministry of Tribal Affairs, in partnership with Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (BPCL), has established 75 Space Labs in Eklavya Model Residential Schools (EMRS) across 18 states, benefiting more than 50,000 students.

The initiative, implemented through BPCL's Corporate Social Responsibility(CSR) programme with an investment of nearly ₹12 crore, aims to provide tribal students with access to advanced scientific learning infrastructure and hands-on exposure to space science and STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics) education.

The Ministry of Tribal Affairs operates Eklavya Model Residential Schools to provide quality residential education to Scheduled Tribe students, supporting their



academic, personal and professional development. Currently, 499 EMRS are functional across the country, serving as centres of excellence for tribal education.

Officials said the newly established Space Labs are designed to promote experiential learning and spark scientific curiosity among students by introducing them to concepts in astronomy, satellite technology, planetary sciences and space exploration.

The project has been implemented through agencies recognised by the Indian

Space Research Organisation (ISRO). Each laboratory is equipped with a range of scientific models and educational tools, including replicas of the LVM3 launch vehicle and Earth Observation satellites, static models of PSLV, HRLV, IRNSS and GSAT missions, astronomy exhibits, tabletop scientific demonstration models, star-tracker telescopes, CanSat working models, STEM learning kits and curated educational resources on India's space programme.

According to officials, the

laboratories will enable students to engage in practical experiments, simulations, model-based demonstrations and observational activities, helping them develop analytical thinking, problem-solving skills and innovation-oriented learning capabilities.

The initiative is expected to bridge educational gaps by bringing advanced STEM infrastructure to remote and tribal regions, ensuring that students receive learning opportunities comparable to those available in urban educational institutions.



Khattar assures Govt support for Assam energy, urban goals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday said Union Minister of Power and Housing and Urban Affairs Manohar Lal Khattar had assured full support from his ministries for the state's efforts to achieve energy self-sufficiency and accelerate urbanisation.

Sharing details of a meeting held at the Union Minister's official residence here late on Sunday night, Sarma said Khattar devoted valuable time to discussions on Assam's development priorities and ensured the presence of senior officials from his ministries to chart out future plans.

"On a Sunday night past 10 pm, he was kind enough to ensure that senior officials of his department were there to help us plan a successful road map to achieve Assam's energy self-sufficiency," the Chief Minister said in a post on X.



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma meeting with Union Minister of Power and Housing and Urban Affairs Manohar Lal Khattar PIONEER PHOTO

According to Chief Minister Sarma, the meeting focused on formulating a roadmap to strengthen Assam's energy sector and advance the state's goal of becoming energy self-sufficient.

The Chief Minister also said Khattar assured the Assam Government that its urbanisation initiatives would receive priority attention, indicating closer cooperation between the Centre and the state on urban infrastructure and development

projects.

Expressing gratitude to the Union Minister, Sarma said the support extended by the ministries would help Assam pursue its long-term objectives in the power and urban development sectors.

Further details regarding specific projects or timelines discussed during the meeting were not immediately disclosed.

Minister of State for External Affairs, Pabitra Margherita was present.

Seminar marks Hindi Patrakarita Divas at Constitution Club



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

A thought-provoking seminar and felicitation ceremony was organised at the Constitution Club in New Delhi on the eve of Hindi Patrakarita Divas, bringing together prominent political leaders, academicians, media personalities and social figures to discuss the role and future of Hindi journalism.

The event witnessed the participation of several distinguished guests, including Delhi Vidhan Sabha Speaker Vijender Gupta, former Union Minister and senior BJP leader Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi, and Professor Chandrakanta of Delhi University.

PROSPECT

Sanjay Lohiya assumes charge as DFS Secretary



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Sanjay Lohiya on Monday assumed charge of the Secretary Department of Financial Services, which administers various Acts related to the banking, insurance and pension sectors.

Lohiya, an IAS of the 1994 batch officer, was serving as Special Secretary in the Department, the DFS said in a post on X.

He succeeds M Nagaraju, who superannuated on May 31. Before joining the Department of Financial

Services (DFS), he was an Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Mines.

During his stint in the Ministry of Mines, he implemented a number of far-reaching reforms in the sector.

The reforms focus on expediting exploration coverage, promoting the private sector in exploration, fast-tracking the auction of mineral concessions and promoting ease of doing business in the mining sector.

He also served as Principal Secretary to the Chief Minister of Assam.

Amaravati emerges on global chess map as VIT-AP hosts international FIDE-rated chess tournament

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Amaravati

Amaravati has taken a significant step toward establishing itself as an international sporting destination with the inauguration of the 1st VIT-AP Amaravati International Chess Tournament 2026, one of the largest international chess events ever organized in Andhra Pradesh.

The tournament, being hosted by VIT-AP University in association with the Andhra Chess Association (ACA), was formally inaugurated on Monday by Andhra Pradesh Director General of Police Harish Kumar Gupta. Inspector General of Police Ake Ravi Krishna attended as the Guest of Honour.

Several dignitaries, including Guntur Superintendent of Police Vakul Jindal, ACA President Dr A Suresh, ACA Chairman KVV Sarma, and ACA Secretary K Jagadish, were also present.

The chess festival comprises two major FIDE-rated events: the VIT-AP Amaravati



International Open Chess Tournament 2026, scheduled from June 1 to June 5, and the VIT-AP Amaravati International Below-18 Unrated Players Chess Tournament 2026, to be held from June 6 to June 8.

Together, the tournaments offer a prize pool of ₹30 lakh. The event has attracted participants from across India and abroad, including players from the United States, highlighting its growing international appeal.

Addressing the gathering, DGP Harish Kumar Gupta emphasized the role of chess in developing strategic thinking and leadership qualities.

ferent regions and countries.

Welcoming players and guests, VIT-AP Vice-Chancellor Professor P Arulmozhivarman said the university remains committed to nurturing critical thinking, innovation, leadership and sporting excellence through initiatives beyond academics.

"Through events such as the Amaravati International Chess Festival, we aim to create opportunities for young talent while showcasing Amaravati as a destination for academic, cultural and sporting excellence," he said.

Guntur Superintendent of Police Vakul Jindal highlighted the importance of sports and intellectual pursuits in shaping responsible and resilient citizens. He said the tournament offers young players an opportunity to challenge themselves, learn from experienced competitors and aspire to greater achievements.

ACA President Dr A Suresh described the tournament as a milestone for chess development in Andhra Pradesh.

Musical drama Sairaab promises soulful tracks, picturesque romance on Star Plus



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Mumbai

Star Plus is set to launch its much-awaited romantic musical drama *Sairaab* on Monday, and viewers appear already emotionally invested in the lead pair even before the first episode goes on air.

Starring Madirakshi Mundle and Rohit Chandel as Noyonika and Ishaan respectively, *Sairaab* has generated buzz for its old-school romantic flavour, soulful music and picturesque visuals. The series follows an unconventional romance between a celebrated pop star and an ordinary woman who has for years been constrained by society's labels and expectations.

Since the promos were released, social media has been abuzz with praise for the fresh concept and the chemistry between the leads. Many viewers said the show evokes the emotionally rich love stories that once defined *Star Plus*, with comments ranging from "Finally, a proper romance" to "This is giving old *Star Plus* vibes."

The excitement heightened when Chandel and Mundle were formally introduced as *Star Plus*'s newest on-screen jodi during the grand *Fashion Ke Rang, Rishton Ke Sang* event that aired on Sunday night. Amid vibrant celebrations, dazzling performances and the congregation of the *Star Parivaar*, audiences got a glimpse of the duo, marking their entry into the channel in style.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.

SOLUTION (1.6.26)

5	4	9	6	8	7	1	2	3
8	1	7	9	3	2	5	6	4
6	2	3	4	1	5	8	9	7
9	5	6	3	2	1	4	7	8
2	3	8	7	6	4	9	1	5
4	7	1	5	9	8	2	3	6
7	8	2	1	4	6	3	5	9
1	9	5	8	7	3	6	4	2
3	6	4	2	5	9	7	8	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

TUESDAY | JUNE 2, 2026

ACROSS

9 It's tea with no frills for father (8)

10 Save soap (3)

11 Away with a woman in America (6)

12 Try to grab and there's a scrap (6)

13 Say you hope it's oven-ready (7)

14 Arrange at the top or bottom of the sheet (4)

15 Meant to give serious thought to (10)

17 How close one is to being a miser? (8)

18 A furious addendum about people who steal the work of others (7)

19 Which of you came to a halt? (4)

21 He painted "The Convert" (6)

24 Being as expansive as you could possibly be? (5,2,3,7)

27 Going up to pack the case, off we went (7)

DOWN

1 Clamorous about an inferior article (10)

2 Covers up, but you notice (4)

3 Is the shopkeeper who sells it only after your money? (8)

4 The one sent off now as a replacement (7)

5 Attractive enough to be given as a gift? (11)

6 Point the damaged tamarinds out - a bird (4,6)

7 Rip off a child and that's the punishment (8)

8 Just a fabrication of lies in an intricate pattern (4,4)

10 Animal from a river in a Scottish island (1)

16 Think I have a mine with silver in it (7)

18 Argued

19 A-miss

20 Actor

21 Cob

22 To-Y

23 Lo-calc

24 Pat

25 Eyelid

26 Green

27 Nanny

28 Regan

29 Ten-able

30 Bin

31 Jan

32 M-e

SOLUTION (1.6.26)

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
9	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20
12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20
12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20
12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20
12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20
12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20
12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20

By order of the Board

For Indag Rubber Limited

Sd/-

Sonal Garg

Company Secretary

(ACS 24598)

Date: May 28, 2026

Place: New Delhi

THE PUNJAB STATE COOPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS FEDERATION LTD.		
SCO 153-155, SECTOR 34-A, CHANDIGARH-160022. EPABX NO. 0172-5041812,66		
Notice Inviting Tender		
Tenders are hereby invited for the purchase and supply of following items:-		www.verka.coop
Sr. No.	Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty
1.	For Verka Head Office, Chandigarh Construction of new SMP Bags store at Verka Patiala Dairy.	Eight Months
2.	For Verka Mohali Dairy a) Supply, installation & commissioning of :- i. Vertical dump lifters (600 kg capacity) for new plant. ii. Motorized vertical conveyor. b) Lifting (purchase) of paneer Whey ex-factory on daily basis.	02 No's 01 No. Annual/ Approximately 20000 kg per/day
3.	For Verka Bathinda Dairy Sale of unserviceable material and scrap.	01 No. Complete job
4.	For Verka Gurdaspur Dairy a) Repair of 6 TPH boiler on turnkey basis. b) Backlit glow sign board, non-ill flex board, flex change. A-type standing flex board, umbrella and vinyl stickers in Himachal Pradesh. c) Supply, installations & commissioning of wood/biomass briquettes fired boiler capacity 3 TPH. d) e-Auction for old used LDPE damaged polyfilm.	01 No. Annual 01 No.
5.	For Verka Hoshiarpur Dairy Hiring of car (Bolero, Swift Dzire, Toyota Etios or Equivalent) required for procurement activities.	01 No.
6.	For Verka Jalandhar Dairy a) Hiring of insulated vehicles for supply of packed milk and fresh milk products in Jalandhar, Kapurthala and Shaheed Bhagat Singh Nagar district. b) Steam Coal having calorific value not less than 5500 kcal/kg. c) Supply of 10kg Dairy Whitener Jar.	Annual 1000 MT Annual
7.	For Verka Ludhiana Dairy a) Insurance of plant, machinery and building (Whole plant/unit including new expansion projects) against fire, earthquake & FST risks / STFI risks (storm, tempest, flood, inundation, hurricanes, cyclone, typhoon, tornado) etc. b) Hiring of innova crystal without driver.	One job 01 No.
8.	For Verka Amritsar Dairy a) Outsourcing of housekeeping & horticulture activities. b) Hiring of vehicle for supply of fresh milk & milk products at:- i. F&B Chaurian & Surrounding area. ii. Local Route c) Branding & Advertising material. d) Outsourcing of Verka Milk Booth at Civil Hospital Ajnala. e) Hiring of Bolero/ Swift Dzire, Toyota Etios/ Seltos or equivalent for official use.model 2020 & above. f) Supply of Indonesian Steam Coal.	Annual Annual Annual Annual Five Years Annual/ 01 No. Office car 1750 MT
9.	For Verka Cattle Feed Plant, Ghania Ke Banger Purchase of Firewood (Fresh cut)	12000 Quintals
NOTE:		
1. For complete details regarding above tender (NIT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in.		
2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.		
1018/12/2026-27/11788		General Manager (Purchase)

BRIEFLY

Marcelo Flores to miss World Cup for Canada after injury



Marcelo Flores is set to miss the World Cup for Canada after injuring his right knee in the CONCACAF Champions Cup final, his club UANL Tigres announced.

Flores, 22, sustained the ACL injury in a non-contact play in the 77th minute on Saturday during Tigres' loss to Toluca. The UANL Tigres said Flores "will undergo surgery in the coming days." "These are difficult times, I just wanted to thank everyone for their messages," Flores posted on Instagram. "I haven't been using my phone or checking my messages, but I promise to reply to everyone and I really appreciate your concern. I'll come back stronger."

Flores' switch of national eligibility from Mexico to Canada was confirmed in February, and he was included in the World Cup squad. Born in Georgetown, Ontario, to a Mexican father, Flores played three matches with Mexico's senior team and needed FIFA approval to play for the Canadians.

(AP)

Kuerten cheers Fonseca at French Open



Former French Open champion Gustavo Kuerten was getting nearly as animated in the front row of the stands as Joao Fonseca was on the court.

In the end, both Brazilians were celebrating after the 19-year-old Fonseca followed up his five-set victory over Novak Djokovic by beating two-time runner-up Casper Ruud 7-5, 7-6 (8), 5-7, 6-2 to reach the quarterfinals at Roland Garros on Sunday. Fonseca is the first Brazilian man to reach the last eight in Paris since - you guessed it - Kuerten in 2004.

Now if Fonseca can win three more matches, he can become the first Brazilian to raise the Coupe des Mousquetaires since Kuerten captured the third of his three titles 25 years ago.

Seated directly behind the court, Kuerten - whose nickname is "Guga" - was gesticulating and cheering for Fonseca from start to finish and it even appeared that Fonseca was looking at him for inspiration on occasion. Kuerten was known for displaying his emotions as a player - never more so than when he used his racket to draw giant hearts on the red clay during a run to the 2001 title. Fonseca, who came back from two sets down against Djokovic, is known for his massive power and high-risk style.

When Ruud had the first of two set points in the second-set tiebreaker, Fonseca rushed the net on his serve and produced a drop-volley that Ruud couldn't get back.

(AP)

Zee to broadcast FIFA World Cup for Indian football fans

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd (ZEEL) on Monday announced an eight-year partnership with world soccer body FIFA to broadcast its all matches, including World Cup 2026, in the Indian market.

As part of a deal with Federation Internationale de Football Association (FIFA), ZEEL will bring 39 FIFA global football events, including FIFA World Cup 2026, that kicks off on June 11, 2026.

The Indian football fans will be able to watch live coverage on ZEEL's sports network and also on its streaming platform ZEE5.

ZEEL will have media rights for FIFA World Cup 2026, FIFA



World Cup 2030, FIFA Women's World Cup in 2027, along with other key FIFA events up to 2034 and docu-series content, for the Indian market, a joint statement said.

"We are excited to bring one of the world's biggest

Finland wins ice hockey world championship

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Zurich

Finland won the ice hockey world championship for the fifth time on Sunday, beating Switzerland 1-0 in overtime.

The Buffalo Sabres' Konsta Helenius scored the gold-winning goal 10:42 into overtime. The 20-year-old Helenius netted from the right circle, beating Switzerland goaltender Leonardo Genoni with his team's 28th shot on goal.

Finland netminder Justus Annunen shut out Switzerland with 22 saves.

"We have a strong culture, you leave your ego outside the locker room, and that's why it's so awesome to come and play for Finland," defenseman Olli Maatta said.



Finland also won in 1995, 2011, 2019 and 2022. Switzerland wasted a two-

minute, 5-on-3 advantage that started six seconds before the end of the

opening period. The final was a rematch of the two teams from their last

group stage game, which the Swiss won 4-2. That was the only loss for

the Finns, who finished second in their preliminary group behind the Swiss. They went on to eliminate the Czechs 4-1 in the quarter finals and upset tournament favorite Canada 4-2 in the semifinals.

Finland was led by captain Aleksander Barkov, who missed the entirety of the Florida Panthers' season because of a major knee injury suffered 20 minutes into his first practice of training camp. The tournament was his first action in competitive games since the Panthers won their second consecutive Stanley Cup last June.

Barkov powered the Finns with three goals and eight assists from 10 games at the worlds.

Indian quartet endures miserable day at Norway Chess

AJAI MASAND ■ Oslo

The Indian contingent endured a miserable outing as all four players suffered defeats in Round 6, with world champion D Gukesh slipping back to losing ways after showing encouraging signs in the previous round, while R Praggnanandhaa, Divya Deshmukh and Koneru Humpy also ended on the wrong side of the results in Norway Chess here.

In stark contrast to the Indians' collective collapse, defending champion and world No. 1 Magnus Carlsen continued his resurgence, securing a classical victory to thrust himself firmly back into title contention.

The Norwegian, who had looked surprisingly vulnerable in the opening rounds, is suddenly gathering



momentum at just the right time, turning what seemed an unlikely campaign into a genuine charge for the crown on home soil.

Yet Carlsen's resurgence has been overshadowed by an unexpected frontrunner. Wesley So of the United States emerged as the sole leader with four rounds remaining after dislodging Alireza Firouzja from the top, while both Carlsen and

Vincent Keymer - the tournament's early strugglers - have launched spirited comeback bids after disastrous starts, ensuring the title race remains wide open heading into the business end of the tournament.

So surged into sole lead on 11.5 points after defeating Praggnanandhaa in a classical game and collecting the full three points, leaving the Indian stranded at the

bottom of the six-player standings on six points.

Keymer capitalised on Gukesh's (6.5 points) severe time trouble to grind out a crucial victory, taking his tally to eight points while handing the world champion another setback in the Open section.

Carlsen, meanwhile, continued his climb up the leaderboard with an authoritative classical win over Firouzja, moving to 7.5 points and fourth place.

For the second successive game, Praggnanandhaa appeared to be on course to hold, and at times even looked capable of turning the tables, but So once again demonstrated his endgame mastery, patiently converting an extra pawn into three points - a formula that has served him remarkably well throughout the tournament. (PTI)

Cristian Volpato selected in Australia's World Cup squad

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Brisbane

Cristian Volpato has been vaulted into Australia's World Cup squad just days after confirming a switch of national eligibility from Italy, and four years after he declined an invitation to join the Socceroos ahead of the 2022 tournament.

Coach Tony Popovic included the 22-year-old Volpato in the 26-man squad announced Monday. Australian time. He and striker Tete Yengi were among 17 players selected in a World Cup squad for the first time.



Skipper Mat Ryan, with 104 international caps, and veteran Mathew Leckie were

picked for a fourth World Cup, equaling the Australian record held by Tim Cahill

and Mark Milligan.

"A range of factors has gone into selecting this final World Cup squad," Popovic said in a statement. "Some difficult decisions had to be made... but it's also a credit to all the players involved who worked extremely hard during an extended and challenging pre-camp.

"I'd like to acknowledge the players who contributed to our direct World Cup qualification but are not part of this squad."

The Sydney-born Volpato played for Italy's Under-21 team but was eligible to make the switch to Australia under FIFA rules because he

never played a competitive game for the senior Italy team. Italy failed to qualify for the World Cup being co-hosted by the US, Mexico and Canada.

Volpato only joined the Socceroos camp in Los Angeles on the weekend, too late to participate in the 1-0 World Cup warmup loss to Mexico at Pasadena.

Australia will play another warmup game on Saturday against Switzerland at San Diego to finetune for Group D games against Turkey at Vancouver on June 13, the U.S. at Seattle six days later and Paraguay at Santa Clara on June 25.

South Africa postpones travel to Mexico for World Cup due to visa issues

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Johannesburg

South Africa's national men's soccer team has postponed its travel to Mexico because of visa issues, just 11 days ahead of the World Cup.

Bafana Bafana were supposed to leave for Mexico on Sunday to start its preparations for the tournament. The team is set to play co-host Mexico in the opening game in Mexico City on June 11.

South African Sports Minister Gayton McKenzie had called the situation "embarrassing" but said later on X that the team would now be departing on Monday.

"All @BafanaBafana



players received their visas to travel to the USA, outstanding is assistant coach, team doctor, head of security and one analyst," McKenzie said.

"The charter will leave tomorrow."

Visa challenges: The South African senior men's nation-

al team has experienced challenges regarding visas for some players and officials, and as a result the group could not travel to North America this morning as originally planned," the South African Football Association said in a statement earlier Sunday.

Dinner for Black players at French Open draws mixed reaction

ANDREW DAMPF ■ Paris

Naomi Osaka and Taylor Townsend are piling up wins on the court at the French Open. Their success comes after drawing attention off the court for organising a dinner for Black players before the tournament started.

"It caused a bit of a stir, which I thought was pretty funny because for so long we have been the ones that (are) the minority in a sport where we kind of stick out," Townsend said about chatter on social media. "And now coming together all of a sudden seems like a problem."

While Townsend said the reaction from her Instagram

post about the evening was "mostly positive," she said there was also online criticism.

Several comments on Osaka's and Townsend's posts suggested the dinner as "segregation," while another asked, "When are the white, Latino, and Asian parties?"

It all prompted Townsend to quote a lyric from the rapper Finesse2tymes: "He said, It's cool when they do it; it's a problem when I do it."

Keeping in the rap theme, Townsend quoted Tupac Shakur in her post about the evening: "Some say the blacker the berry, the sweeter the juice; I say the darker the flesh, then the deeper the roots."

Besides Osaka and Townsend, the other attendees of the dinner were 2025 French Open champion Coco Gauff, retiring Frenchman Gael Monfils, doubles specialist Asia Muhammad and retired player turned TV commentator Chris Eubanks.

"Growing up, there weren't a lot of tennis players I could look up to that looked like me," Osaka - whose father is from Haiti and mother is from Japan - said in her Instagram post about the dinner. "Being a minority in a sport like tennis is very isolating but the positive is that you keep tabs on everyone that being blind, is black. There's a fellowship, a camaraderie."



"I felt like everyone in that room was a part of my family," Osaka - who represents Japan but grew up mostly in the US - added in a news conference.

For Townsend, "it wasn't just about the culture, it was healing for us to all be able to speak about our journeys."

While Gauff's title defense ended with a loss to Anastasia Potapova on Saturday, Osaka has reached the fourth round in Paris for the first time in her career while showing off her taste for fashion with her elaborate walk-on outfits. American player Townsend and Czech partner Katerina Siniakova - the top-seeded doubles team

- have won their opening three matches and are into the quarterfinals.

Althea Gibson broke tennis' color barrierGauff beat Townsend in the opening round of singles, after which a ceremony was held on Court Philippe-Chatrier to honor the 70th anniversary of Althea Gibson's 1956 French Open victory - the first Grand Slam title for a Black tennis player.

Gibson was also the first Black player to compete at a major tennis tournament when she fought with the US Lawn Tennis Association just to get admitted in 1950 to what was then called the US Nationals - now the US Open. "Taylor and I playing on

Philippe-Chatrier is a direct product of Althea Gibson," Gauff told the crowd after beating Townsend. "It just shows the importance of breaking barriers in all aspects of the world, but especially in sport. I'm very grateful for people like her and Serena and Venus (Williams), Zina Garrison for paving the way for us."

Soul Food' Sunday at WimbledonThe dinner recalls how going back to the Harlem Renaissance, Black athletes, entertainers, musicians and writers held salons and dinners to celebrate their successes in familial space. Such events were not meant as a slight to non-Blacks. (PTI)

Virat Kohli reinvents his T20 game

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Indian superstar Virat Kohli said he needed a change in mindset and a bit of pushing from “super young” players to reinvent his T20 game after he smashed his fastest IPL fifty to power Royal Challengers Bengaluru to their second successive trophy.

In the IPL final against Gujarat Titans on Sunday, he fulfilled his long-cherished dream of hitting the winning runs for the franchise.

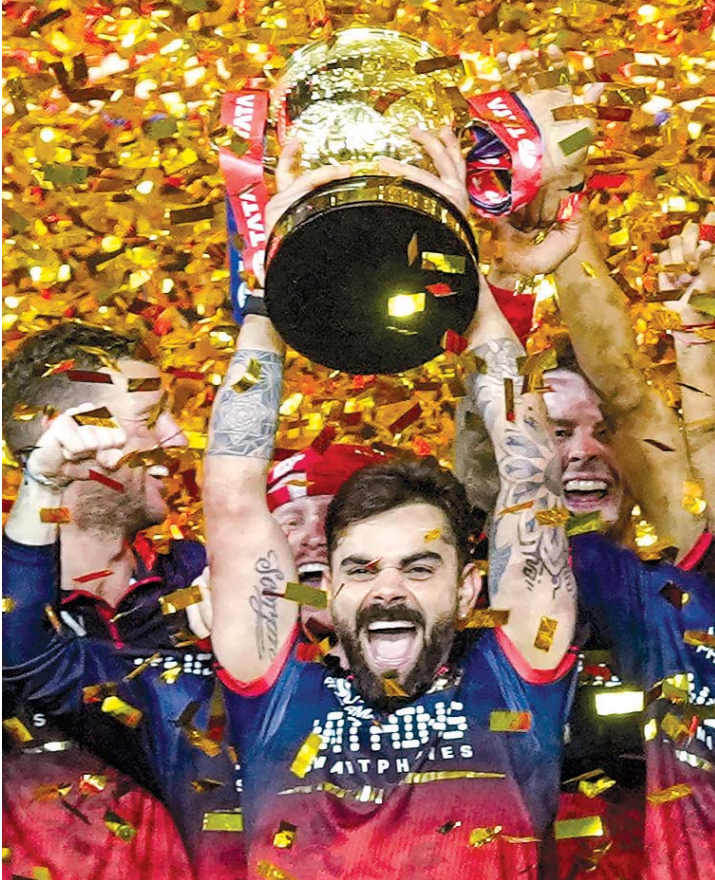
Kohli’s unbeaten 75 was the cornerstone of RCB’s second IPL title and the legend couldn’t be more pleased with the amount of consistency he showed throughout the season.

“(It is the) stuff you dream of. (I) thought of this moment many times, wanting to hit the winning run,” Kohli said at the post-match presentation ceremony.

Asked about his 25-ball half-century, Kohli showed why he eternally remains a student of the game.

“Such is the demand (that) super young players (are) pushing you to up the ante,” he said in jest, but the seriousness of his statement wasn’t lost on anyone.

“I had to change my mindset, not my game so much, take on bowlers and get extra runs,” he added.



Royal Challengers Bengaluru’s Virat Kohli and others celebrate with the tournament trophy during the presentation ceremony after winning the Indian Premier League (IPL) 2026 title, in Ahmedabad, Gujarat

What has pleased Kohli this season is the fact that in the first 10 games, there were eight different cricketers who won the Player of the Match award.

“We’ve had to wait for so long and then just to have a group of guys where you feel like you’re stepping onto the ground, you don’t need to be the one to step up every time,” Kohli said.

“These guys are behind you (and) around you, who can win games of cricket for you. We have so many Man of the Match awards spread throughout the group as well.”

“You look at world-class bowling of Hoff (Josh Hazlewood), Bhuv (Bhuvneshwar Kumar), Duff (Jacob Duffy), and Krunal Pandya — you can bank on him as good as ever — Rasikh (Salam) Dar was brilliant this season,” Kohli said.

The kind of team that RCB management put on the park during the last two seasons has made the difference, feels Kohli.

“I felt really relaxed coming in. The team we have gives confidence to see any kind of situation through. (We) knew exactly what to do in the chase.”

Very carefully, he also spoke about how they didn’t care which team was in the opposition but at the same time, there was respect for each and every other opponent.

“Our first target was to go top of

the table. We didn’t care what jersey was in front of us thereon. We are respectful, don’t poke any team. We have mature professionals and experience shines through.”

For him, on big days, it is the duty of the stars to pull the team through.

“Come the big situation, you need the big boys to step up. I know it’s a chase and they’ll look to get me out early, but I knew we have a champion side that can chase it down with 3-4 overs to go.”

Having missed the bus for 17 seasons, Kohli remembers what Director of Cricket Mo Bobat told them after their maiden win in 2025.

“When we won last year, Mo Bobat said this is not the end of the journey and we had to go back-to-back. At the start of the chase, I told Venky (Venkatesh Iyer) that we need to kill the game in the power-play. There was total clarity.”

Kohli said the final this year felt a lot different than last year.

“I said to a few of the boys that it doesn’t feel like the same pressure as last year, we knew what kind of ability we have in the group,” he said.

“We topped the table, there’s a reason why we got here first and we just said one thing, ‘if we stick to our cricket, if we execute our plans, we are the best team in the competition’ and there’s a reason why we’ve done well so far.”



I learnt how to play in pressure situation: Sooryavanshi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi blew the IPL 2026 away with his record-breaking strokeplay but the 15-year-old batting sensation says he also has learnt to shift gears according to the game situation, remaining calm under pressure, and working on his fitness to remain injury-free.

While his team Rajasthan Royals failed to make the final after losing to eventual runners-up Gujarat Titans in Qualifier 2, the left-handed batter was adjudged the Most Valuable Player of the tournament. Sooryavanshi topped the batting chart with 776 runs from 16 innings at an

average of 48.50 and a stunning strike rate of 237.30, hitting one century and five fifties to win the Orange Cap.

“This season, I learnt how to play in pressure games, (and) how to change your game,” said the 15-year-old after collecting his award after the final here on Sunday.

“You cannot play every game in one mode. You will have to read the situation of the game and play according to the requirements of the team. I got to learn this a lot in the playoff games too.”

Sooryavanshi surpassed West Indian Chris Gayle’s previous IPL record of maximum number of sixes (59) in a season, as he smashed 72 maximums in IPL 2026.



Hazlewood says keeping core team intact worked for RCB

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Jose Hazlewood believes keeping the core team intact did the trick for Royal Challengers Bengaluru’s back-to-back title wins, while his pace colleague Bhuvneshwar Kumar credited the success to meticulous planning by the team as the players soaked in the glory of their IPL triumph here on Sunday.

A dominant RCB won their second successive title with Virat Kohli anchoring the team to beat Gujarat Titans by five wickets in the summit clash here.

“I think the franchise have put together beautifully. Great support staff. It’s tough to build that culture so fast when the teams change every three years,” Hazlewood said after the match.

“This (title win) is right up there. We had to wait a long time for the first win last year. More relaxed with the group (now), got the monkey off the back last year. Calm and composed throughout. Someone or other stepped up. (We won) 10 Player of the Match awards,” said the Australian.

On Bhuvneshwar’s stunning show this season, Hazlewood said, “Can’t

remember a game where he went over 35 runs. Took wickets, we could be relaxed. It’s nice.”

On his part, Bhuvneshwar, who took 28 wickets this season, said, “Yes, the trophy is the most important. I would trade it with the Purple Cap. The season went well, there was a lot of planning ahead of it.

“If you take wickets, the confidence is up. Coming into a big game, (the) past wins give you confidence. We were at our best and that’s what we needed.”

All-rounder Krunal Pandya said it was a special moment to win the title again.

“There’s no doubt about it, everything is special. It’s like having kids, winning IPL titles is also hard to achieve, so everything feels special to me.

“A lot of credit goes to the support staff: Mo Bobat, Andy Flower, DK (Dinesh Karthik), Malolan (Rangarajan). Half of the win is in the auction and we did a good job, I’m glad we went back-to-back for the trophies. 18 years of waiting, (winning) back-to-back trophies, it’s special.

“Also to Virat Kohli, waited 18 years and now winning two titles on the back...”

For batter Devdutt Padikkal, having Kohli in the middle calmed his nerves in the match.

I had to change my mindset not my game: Virat Kohli

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

At 37 and a half, Virat Kohli still believes in working on his game as he smashed the fastest T20 half-century of his career while fulfilling his long-cherished dream of hitting the winning runs in RCB’s IPL winning chase.

Kohli’s unbeaten 75 was the cornerstone of RCB’s second IPL title and the legend couldn’t be more pleased with a dominant effort throughout the season.

“(It is the) stuff you dream of. (I) thought of this moment many times, wanting to hit the winning run,” Kohli said at the post-match presentation ceremony.

Asked about his 25-ball

half-century, Kohli showed why he eternally remains a student of the game.

“Such is the demand (that) super young players (are) pushing you to up the ante,” he said in jest, but the seriousness of his statement wasn’t lost on anyone.

“I had to change my mindset, not my game so much, take on bowlers and get extra runs,” he added.

What has pleased Kohli this season is the fact that in the first 10 games, there were eight different cricketers who won the Player of the Match award. It is no longer a case of the campaign resting on his shoulders.

“We’ve had to wait for so long and then just to have a



group of guys where you feel like you’re stepping onto the ground, you don’t need to be the one to step up every time,” Kohli said.

“These guys are behind you (and) around you, who can win games of cricket for you. We have so many Man of the Match awards spread

No RCB victory parade in Bengaluru

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Ahmedabad

The passionate fans will not be able to celebrate Royal Challengers Bengaluru’s title defence with the team after the franchise decided against holding a victory parade in the city in order to avoid the crowd frenzy, which led to last year’s deadly stampede.

The Royal Challengers lifted their second consecutive IPL title, beating Gujarat Titans by five wickets here on Sunday.

The RCB took such a decision also keeping in mind the swearing-in ceremony of newly-appointed Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar.

The function is scheduled to be held at Lok Bhavan at 4.10 pm and the Governor’s residence is in close proximity to Chinnaswamy Stadium. The political function is expected to attract a massive crowd from across the state.

The ceremony, which is to be attended by several dignitaries, will also require considerable deployment of police personnel, and it will be tough for the state police department to spare men for another high-voltage function.

In that context, the RCB



management felt that it was better to adhere to the police notification, prohibiting public celebrations on city streets.

On June 4, 2025, 11 fans were killed near Chinnaswamy Stadium as RCB hastily arranged a victory parade following their maiden title win, and clearly no one wanted a repeat of that this year.

That tragic chain of events had invoked huge public outrage and the intervention of state government and judicial powers, including the High Court.

“It is highly unlikely that there will be any activities in Bengaluru. There are certain guidelines in place, and we need to stick to them,” a RCB source indicated to PTI.

Bengaluru city police on Friday had issued an advisory urging the public to avoid bursting crackers, holding road celebrations, creating disturbances or engaging in fights if RCB win the IPL final.

“We have issued an advisory asking fans not to celebrate publicly on the streets and especially not to disturb peace and security.

“We will not allow any

public celebrations. If anyone wants to celebrate, they can do it indoors,” Bengaluru City Police Commissioner Seemant Kumar Singh had said.

Besides, RCB top-order batter Devdutt Padikkal will have to join the Indian Test squad on Mullanpur by Wednesday ahead of the one-off Test against Afghanistan, while others like Josh Hazlewood, Tim David (Australia), Jacob Duffy (New Zealand) and Romario Shepherd (West Indies) too have upcoming national team commitments. (PTI)

GT players, staff evacuated from team bus after mid-road breakdown

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Ahmedabad

In a safety scare for the Gujarat Titans players and support staff, they had to be evacuated from the team bus after a short circuit caused a breakdown of the vehicle while it was ferrying them back to their hotel after the IPL final loss to Royal Challenge Bengaluru here.

PTI learned that the team members, who are all safe and unhurt despite smoke spreading inside the bus, waited on the road for a short while before another bus was arranged to take them to the hotel.

The incident added to a

miserable night for GT as they had earlier gone down to Royal Challengers Bengaluru in the IPL final by five wickets here on Sunday.

It was also a continuation of their tough travel itinerary as GT had to travel from Dharamsala to Mullanpur on May 27 to play the Qualifier 2 against Rajasthan Royals on May 29. However, their scheduled departure to Ahmedabad on May 30 was inordinately delayed because of inclement weather in Mullanpur. GT reached their home base late on Saturday evening.

Was fatigue a reason for the Titans’ meek surrender to RCB in the IPL final? (PTI)



Patidar dedicates IPL trophy to stampede victims

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Ahmedabad

Royal Challengers Bengaluru skipper Rajat Patidar shelved his stoic side for a few moments and dedicated his team’s second IPL trophy to the fans who died in the stampede last year.

The hurriedly organised victory celebrations of RCB after they won their maiden IPL title in June last year led to a stampede, causing the death of 11 fans outside the



M Chinnaswamy Stadium. “Obviously, you feel bad. You lost your fans after winning the game. Not just the fans, they are the family members,” Patidar said in the post-match press conference after RCB beat Gujarat Titans by five wickets to bag their second IPL title in a row here on Sunday night. “I always want to dedicate this trophy to them. That’s it. I don’t have words to express that feeling,” he added. (PTI)

We dominated this year: Rajat Patidar

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Ahmedabad

Royal Challengers Bengaluru’s second IPL title win came on Rajat Patidar’s 33rd birthday but more than that happy coincidence the skipper was pleased with his team’s start-to-end domination in the league.

RCB were an unstoppable force from the opening match where they decimated Sunrisers Hyderabad at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium.

That bull run reached its logical conclusion at the Narendra Modi Stadium with a five-wicket win over Gujarat Titans in the IPL final on Sunday.

“To be honest, last year was a lot of pressure. This year was more calm because of the way we played throughout the tournament. I think we have not just played, we dominated this year,” said Patidar in the post-match press conference. “So we were pretty much

confident that if we are playing like this, we are definitely going to win the second title for RCB,” he added.

He also sent out a cold message for contenders — RCB are far from finished. “It is the best gift because it is my birthday today (Sunday). It feels good overall, but as an individual, I try to stay in the present. We will have to focus more on how we can do three in a row,” he said. (PTI)